

Cover letter

Dear Members of the Recruitment Committee,

I am writing to apply for the position of Assistant Professor in Digital Marketing and Data Analytics at EMLV Business School, Paris La Défense. I completed my PhD in Management (Marketing) at the University of Southern Queensland in 2026. I currently work as Program Director and Lecturer in Marketing at Hoa Sen University and as a Sessional Academic at Griffith University.

My research asks what happens to consumer and organisational decisions when artificial intelligence becomes part of them. I study consumer well-being, influencer marketing, artificial intelligence, AI-enabled sustainable marketing, marketing ethics, and technology-mediated consumption. My methods include experiments, structural equation modelling (SEM), machine learning, natural language processing (NLP), and mixed methods. My most recent project examines zero-click GenAI recommendations and combines SEM with machine learning to explain the purchase decisions that follow. My work has been published in Journal of Sustainable Tourism (AJG-3), Psychology & Marketing (AJG-3), International Journal of Consumer Studies (AJG-2), Journal of Enterprise Information Management (AJG-2), The Service Industries Journal (AJG-2), and Journal of Internet Commerce (AJG-1).

On the analytics side, I work mainly in R, RStudio, and SPSS. My toolkit covers SEM, PLS-SEM, regression modelling, factorial experiments, Random Forest, Elastic Net, XGBoost, SHAP, Bayesian Networks, and NLP. I use these tools to test and build marketing theory as well as to predict outcomes, and I bring the same approach into the classroom. I am prepared to teach Digital Marketing, Marketing Research, Business Analytics, Artificial Intelligence in Marketing, Consumer Behaviour, and Digital Business.

At Hoa Sen University I run a program as well as teach in it. My responsibilities include curriculum development, course design, program review, academic quality assurance, faculty coordination, student engagement, and university–industry collaboration. I prepared accreditation evidence for our AUN-QA review and represented the program in meetings with the international assessment panel. I have redesigned ten undergraduate courses to bring AI and data analytics into teaching and assessment. I also use live cases, company visits, practitioner sessions, and industry projects so that students work on real problems. My average student evaluation is 4.8/5, and I have taught more than 5,000 learners across university courses and professional training.

This semester I supervise 15 Bachelor's thesis students and 9 Master's by Research students, mostly in marketing, consumer behaviour, and digital technologies. I would be glad to supervise MSc, MBA, and Master students at EMLV and to contribute to pedagogical program management, research activities, and the wider academic life of the School.

EMLV's place within De Vinci Higher Education, alongside engineering and digital programs, is a large part of why this role appeals to me. My work already sits between marketing and data science, and I would value working with colleagues and students who move comfortably across both.

Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the chance to discuss my research, teaching, and academic leadership with the committee.

Sincerely,

Dr. Tuan (Todd) Cao

tuan.cao@griffith.edu.au 

[tuantoddcao.github.io](https://github.com/tuantoddcao) 

Tuan (Todd) Cao

Marketing & Consumer Behaviour Scholar | Digital Marketing & Artificial Intelligence
| Sustainable Marketing | Marketing Ethics

tuan.cao@griffith.edu.au  | tuantoddcao.github.io 

Research Expertise

Research Areas: Sustainable Marketing and Consumer Behaviour; Consumer Psychographics and Individual Differences; Artificial Intelligence and Human-AI Interaction; Consumer Well-Being; Digital Marketing and Digital Transformation; AI-Enabled Decision-Making; Digital Ethics and Responsible Technology.

Academic Appointments

Griffith University, Australia — Sessional Academic

2025–Present

- Contribute to research projects in Marketing, Consumer Behaviour, Artificial Intelligence, and emerging digital technologies.
- Conduct research design, survey development, data collection, and quantitative and qualitative data analysis for international research projects.
- Contribute to manuscript development, research ethics applications, and responses to reviewers for peer-reviewed journal publications.
- Collaborate with academic researchers on research design, advanced data analysis, project coordination, and publication development.

Hoa Sen University, Vietnam — Program Director & Lecturer in Marketing

2025–Present

- Teach Research in Marketing, Marketing and Business Fundamentals, Corporate Communications, Crisis Management, and Introduction to Public Relations.
- Lead programme development, curriculum review, course design, academic quality assurance, and accreditation activities.
- Develop programme content and accreditation evidence for AUN-QA review and represent the programme during meetings and interviews with accreditation panels.
- Lead programme coordination, faculty planning, student engagement, and university–industry collaboration.

Van Lang University, Vietnam — Lecturer in Marketing

2023–2024

- Taught undergraduate courses in Principles of Marketing, Consumer Behaviour, and Business Analytics.

Nguyen Tat Thanh University, Vietnam — Lecturer in Management

2020–2023

- Taught undergraduate courses in E-Commerce, Strategic Marketing, and International Business.

Education

PhD in Management (Marketing)

University of Southern Queensland, Australia

2026

PhD in Business Administration

Open University, Vietnam

Conferral pending

Master of Business Administration (MBA)

Open University, Vietnam

2017–2019

Current Research Programme

Digital Marketing, Artificial Intelligence, and Human–AI Interaction Examine how consumers respond to Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI), AI-generated recommendations, synthetic endorsers, AI-mediated services, and emerging forms of human–AI interaction in digital markets.

Sustainable Marketing, Consumption, and Consumer Well-Being Investigate sustainable consumer behaviour, sustainability communication, green-rinsing, and the psychological and digital mechanisms that shape sustainable decision-making and consumer well-being.

Consumer Psychographics and Individual Differences Study how values, self-concept, perceptions, and other individual differences shape consumer responses to artificial intelligence, digital technologies, brands, and consumption experiences.

Digital Ethics and Responsible Technology Explore the ethical and societal implications of AI-enabled decision-making, synthetic media, automated persuasion, and technology-mediated consumption, with particular attention to trust, responsibility, and consumer welfare.

Selected Peer-Reviewed Journal Publications

Accepted | ABDC A* | AJG-3

Mai, N., **Cao, T. T.***, & Yunen, Z. (Forthcoming). How hotels communicate sustainability goal revisions: The role of perceived green-rinsing, influencer type, and sustainability solutions. *Journal of Sustainable Tourism*.

Published | ABDC A | AJG-3

Cao, T. T.*, Prentice, C., Wang, Q., & Nguyen, S. (2025). Financial self-discrepancy, consumer well-being, and luxury preferences: The moderating effect of access-based luxury formats. *Psychology & Marketing*, 43, 357–373. doi.org/10.1002/mar.70057

Published | ABDC A | AJG-2

Cao, T. T., Prentice, C., Wang, Q., & Nguyen, H. S.* (2026). Conflicted by faith, drawn to pleasure: How religious self-discrepancy shapes product choices. *International Journal of Consumer Studies*, 50(2), e70202. doi.org/10.1111/ijcs.70202

Published | ABDC A | AJG-2

Cao, T. T.*, Prentice, C., Wang, Q., & Nguyen, H. S. (2025). Compensatory consumption: A review and research agenda using the theory-context-characteristics-methodology framework. *International Journal of Consumer Studies*, 49(5), e70112. doi.org/10.1111/ijcs.70112

Published | ABDC A | AJG-2

Cao, T. T., Yunen, Z., & Tuan, N.* (2026). When Generative Artificial Intelligence becomes a counsellor: How employee evaluations shape engagement and organizational attractiveness. *Journal of Enterprise Information Management*. doi.org/10.1108/JEIM-02-2026-0238

Accepted | ABDC A | AJG-2

Tuan, N., & **Cao, T. T.*** (Forthcoming). Working with GenAI: How human-centered mindset and GenAI understanding drive employee autonomy and competence. *Journal of Enterprise Information Management*.

Accepted | ABDC A | AJG-2

Cao, T. T., Mai, N., Tuan, N.*, Malik, A., & Anjali, T. (Forthcoming). AI leadership: Employee perceptions and pathways to compliance. *The Service Industries Journal*.

Published | ABDC B | AJG-1

Cao, T. T., & Tuan, N.* (2026). Understanding consumer purchase intention toward Zero-Click GenAI-generated recommendations: Evidence from structural equation modeling and machine learning. *Journal of Internet*

Other Peer-Reviewed Journal Publications

Published | Peer-Reviewed Journal

Cao, T. T.* (2025). Self-discrepancy and gambling retention: A conceptual model of motivational and moral pathways. *Strategic Business Research*, 1(1), 100001. doi.org/10.1016/j.sbr.2025.100001

Published | Peer-Reviewed Journal

Cao, T. T., & Nguyen, S.* (2024). Navigating dual identities: How bicultural consumers leverage luxury consumption to cope with perceived discrimination and enhance well-being. *Journal of Development and Integration*, 85, 106–116. doi.org/10.61602/jdi.2025.85.12

Published | Peer-Reviewed Journal

Ha, N. M., & **Cao, T. T.*** (2019). Constructing athlete identification and the effectiveness of athlete endorsement on customer's purchase intention. *Journal of Distribution Science*, 17(8). doi.org/10.15722/jds.17.8.201908.87

* Corresponding author

Manuscripts Under Review

Second-Round Revision | ABDC A* | AJG-3

Yunen, Z., **Cao, T. T.***, & Mai, N. (2025). The right endorser for the right stay: How human and AI endorsers differ across privacy levels and service modes in accommodation booking intention. *International Journal of Hospitality Management*.

Under Review | ABDC A* | AJG-3

Cao, T. T.*, Nguyen, M., & Nham, T. P. (2026). When hotels revise sustainability goals: A paradox theory perspective on perceived green-rinsing and consumer evaluation. *Journal of Sustainable Tourism*.

Under Review | ABDC A* | AJG-4

Cao, T. T.*, Cheah, I., & Liu, X. (2026). AI-curated sustainable hotel hopping: A push-pull-mooring perspective on travelers' delegation decisions. *Journal of Travel Research*.

Under Review | FT50 | ABDC A*

Yunen, Z., Mai, N., & **Cao, T. T.*** (2026). When synthetic endorsers are morally acceptable: Context-dependent consumer responses to AI-generated synthetic endorsers. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*.

Additional manuscripts are currently under peer review in sustainability, tourism, artificial intelligence, and consumer research, including submissions to

Book Chapters

Accepted

Nguyen, S., Phan, H., **Cao, T. T.**, Nguyen, M., & Zhang, Y. (Forthcoming). The evolution of AI in marketing. In *AI in Marketing: From Augmented Intelligence to Autonomous Markets*. Springer Nature.

Accepted

Phan, H. N. Q., Nguyen, S., **Cao, T. T.**, Nguyen, M., & Zhang, Y. (Forthcoming). GenAI in marketing. In *AI in Marketing: From Augmented Intelligence to Autonomous Markets*. Springer Nature.

Accepted

Phan, H., Nguyen, S., **Cao, T. T.**, Nguyen, M., & Zhang, Y. (Forthcoming). Synthetic media and AI influencers. In *AI in Marketing: From Augmented Intelligence to Autonomous Markets*. Springer Nature.

Accepted

Phan, H., Do, T., **Cao, T. T.**, Nguyen, M., & Zhang, Y. (Forthcoming). Conversational AI and customer interaction. In *AI in Marketing: From Augmented Intelligence to Autonomous Markets*. Springer Nature.

Accepted

Do, T., Phan, H., **Cao, T. T.**, Nguyen, M., & Zhang, Y. (Forthcoming). AI in customer experience and journeys. In *AI in Marketing: From Augmented Intelligence to Autonomous Markets*. Springer Nature.

Accepted

Phan, H., Do, T., **Cao, T. T.**, Nguyen, M., & Zhang, Y. (Forthcoming). AI-to-AI interactions in marketing. In *AI in Marketing: From Augmented Intelligence to Autonomous Markets*. Springer Nature.

Conference Presentations

21st International Forum on Knowledge Asset Dynamics (IFKAD), Hungary

2026

Cao, T. T., Ashish, M., & Mai, N. Employee evaluations of AI-generated leaders: A mixed-methods analysis of uncanniness, transparency, and employee outcomes.

Research Funding and Competitive Grant Experience

National Foundation for Science and Technology Development (NAFOSTED), Vietnam

2026

- **Role: Key Research Member** on a national competitive research proposal recommended for funding.
- Contributed to research design, methodological development, and proposal preparation.
- Total proposed funding: VND 3 billion.

Ministry of Education and Training Research Grant (B2024-MBS-09), Vietnam

2024

- **Role: Key Research Member** on a successfully completed government-funded research project.
- Contributed to research development, data analysis, and project outputs.
- Grant value: approximately USD 20,000.

Teaching Expertise and Supervision

- Consumer Behaviour; Digital Marketing; Sustainable Marketing; Marketing Ethics; Marketing Strategy; International Marketing; Branding; Marketing Research; Business Analytics; Artificial Intelligence in Marketing; Digital Business and E-Commerce; Corporate Communication.
- Currently supervise 15 Bachelor's thesis students and 9 Master's by Research students.
- More than five years of university teaching experience in Marketing, Consumer Behaviour, Digital Marketing, Marketing Research, Business Analytics, Digital Business, and Corporate Communication.
- Achieved an average student evaluation score of 4.8/5 at Hoa Sen University.
- Redesigned 10 undergraduate courses using student-centred, technology-enhanced, and applied learning approaches.
- Integrate artificial intelligence, digital technologies, data analytics, and current industry cases into marketing teaching and assessment.
- Connect classroom learning with practice through company visits, practitioner sessions, live cases, and industry partnerships.
- Delivered university teaching and professional training to more than 5,000 learners from diverse academic and professional backgrounds.
- Trained and mentored more than 30 teachers in teaching practice, classroom delivery, and student engagement.
- Mentored more than 200 students who achieved IELTS scores of 7.0 or above.
- Received institutional recognition for teaching excellence across multiple consecutive years.

Industry and Professional Experience

NIS International School, Vietnam — Brand Manager

2016–2020

- Managed campus operations and coordinated cross-functional teams.
- Increased student enrolment by approximately 10% annually from 2017 to 2020.
- Led brand communication and stakeholder engagement strategies.
- Developed partnerships with community organisations, media, and external stakeholders.

Advanced Research Methods and Data Analytics

Research Designs: Mixed-methods research; between-subjects experiments; cross-sectional research; factorial experiments; difference-in-differences designs; qualitative interviews; systematic literature reviews.

Statistical and Quantitative Methods: Structural Equation Modelling (SEM); PLS-SEM; regression modelling; quantitative survey analysis, difference-in-differences analysis; .

Machine Learning and Computational Methods: Random Forest; Elastic Net; XGBoost; SHAP; Bayesian Networks; Grow-Shrink and Hill-Climbing algorithms; Natural Language Processing (NLP); text clustering; consumer archetype identification.

Software and Digital Tools: R; RStudio; SPSS; LaTeX; Quarto; GitHub.

Peer-Review Service

Serve on the Editorial Board of the Strategic Business Research Journal and conduct peer review for internationally refereed journals across Marketing, Management, Information Systems, and Tourism and Hospitality.

Editorial Board: *Strategic Business Research*.

Marketing: Psychology & Marketing; International Journal of Consumer Studies; Frontiers in Psychology; Strategic Business Research.

Management and Information Systems: Journal of Enterprise Information Management; Journal of Internet Commerce; Employee Relations.

Tourism and Hospitality: Journal of Hospitality and Tourism Management.

Awards, Scholarships and Academic Recognition

Full PhD Scholarship and Stipend, University of Southern Queensland, Australia

2024–2026

Approximate value: USD 123,000.

Valedictorian, Master's Programme, Open University, Vietnam

2019

Graduated with the highest GPA and highest Master's thesis defence score in the programme.

Dedicated Teacher Award

2019–2021

Awarded for three consecutive years in recognition of teaching excellence and student engagement.

Most Excellent Teacher Award

2018

International Accreditation Recognition

University representative for FIBAA accreditation and quality assurance activities.

Full Master's Scholarship, Open University, Vietnam

2017–2019

Approximate value: USD 6,000.

Languages

English: Full professional proficiency; IELTS Academic overall score: 8.0.

Vietnamese: Native proficiency.

Academic Referees

Professor Catherine Prentice

Head of Marketing Discipline
University of Southern Queensland, Australia
Catherine.Prentice@unisq.edu.au 

Dr Jenny (Qingxia) Wang

Senior Lecturer
University of Southern Queensland, Australia
Jenny.Wang2@unisq.edu.au 

Dr Mai Nguyen

Insight Lab Co-Director
Griffith Business School, Griffith University, Australia
m.nguyen2@griffith.edu.au 

Statement of research interests and direction

My research examines how artificial intelligence, sustainability, and consumer psychology reshape decision-making, market interactions, and consumer well-being. My research programme develops across three connected streams: AI and emotion-based roles, sustainability and AI, and consumer psychographics.

AI, Emotions, and Human–AI Relationships

My first stream examines whether AI can move beyond prediction, recommendation, and automation to perform roles that have traditionally depended on human judgement, emotion, and social presence. My published research has examined AI as a counsellor and AI-enabled leadership, focusing on how people respond when machines take on roles associated with guidance, authority, support, and interpersonal influence.

This work addresses a broader question: can AI use logic, data, and adaptive interaction to perform functions that humans normally associate with emotion? The question becomes increasingly important as AI enters roles that depend not only on technical accuracy, but also on trust, empathy, social acceptance, and perceived authenticity.

In marketing, this stream extends to AI doppelgangers and long-term consumer–AI relationships. AI can move beyond one-off chatbot recommendations and become a shopping companion that understands a consumer's preferences, identity, habits, constraints, and goals. This changes the role of AI from recommendation to companionship and delegation.

Sustainability, AI, and Imperfect Consumption

My second stream examines sustainability in situations where environmentally costly behaviour cannot simply be avoided. One example is hotel hopping, an increasingly visible travel pattern in which consumers stay at multiple hotels during one trip. In lieu of treating hotel hopping as behaviour that consumers should stop, my research examines how AI can help consumers manage it more sustainably through better coordination of accommodation, transport, and related decisions.

This stream also develops research on perceived green-rinsing. Our work is among the early studies to introduce green-rinsing into consumer and tourism research and examines how consumers respond when firms revise, delay, or reduce previously stated sustainability commitments. The concept captures an important distinction between greenwashing and situations in which consumers perceive a firm as retreating from its existing environmental goals.

These projects share the same principle: sustainable marketing should not only ask consumers to avoid undesirable behaviour. It should also examine how technology can help consumers manage unavoidable trade-offs, reduce environmental costs, and make more sustainable decisions within the realities of everyday consumption.

Consumer Psychographics and Self-Discrepancy

My third stream focuses on consumer psychographics and individual differences, with self-discrepancy as a central theoretical lens. My research examines how gaps between the actual self, ideal self, and expected self influence consumption, consumer well-being, luxury preferences, moral conflict, and compensatory behaviour.

This stream extends self-discrepancy theory into AI-mediated consumption. AI systems increasingly learn consumers' preferences, aspirations, vulnerabilities, and identities. When AI recognises the gap between who consumers are and who they want to become, it can influence the products, services, experiences, and recommendations presented to them.

This creates a direct connection between consumer psychology, personalisation, AI-enabled decision-making, and consumer well-being. It also provides a foundation for examining when personalised AI supports consumers and when it exploits psychological vulnerabilities.

Direction: Consumer Well-Being, Equitelligence, and Machine Unlearning _____

The next stage of my research brings these three streams together around consumer well-being and responsible artificial intelligence. A central part of this direction is the development of Equitelligence, a corporate social responsibility perspective for the AI era.

Traditional CSR frameworks emphasise economic, legal, ethical, and philanthropic responsibilities. AI creates an additional responsibility: organisations must ensure that AI-supported decisions are equitable, transparent, explainable, and worthy of human trust. Equitelligence addresses how organisations design, govern, and evaluate AI when automated decisions affect consumers, employees, and other stakeholders.

Machine unlearning forms another part of this research direction. Responsible AI depends not only on what systems learn, but also on what they should forget. Outdated, biased, sensitive, or inappropriate information can continue to shape automated decisions long after it should have been removed. Machine unlearning therefore connects technical AI development with marketing ethics, consumer privacy, fairness, trust, and corporate responsibility.

Statement of teaching interests and philosophy

Courses Taught and Teaching Interests _____

I have taught Research in Marketing, Marketing and Business Fundamentals, Principles of Marketing, Consumer Behaviour, Strategic Marketing, Business Analytics, E-Commerce, International Business, Corporate Communications, Crisis Management, and Introduction to Public Relations.

I would be particularly interested in contributing to courses that connect closely with my research and teaching experience, including Understanding the Elusive Consumer, Marketing Research, Strategic Brand Management, Sustainable Marketing & Communication, Digital Marketing, Advanced Quantitative Methods, and Advanced Strategic Marketing. I would also welcome opportunities to develop or contribute to courses in Artificial Intelligence in Marketing, Human–AI Interaction, Digital Marketing, Marketing Ethics, and Consumer Well-Being.

Evidence of research activity

Writing Sample 1 — Accepted for Publication

Mai, N., **Cao, T. T.**, & Yunen, Z. (Forthcoming). How hotels communicate sustainability goal revisions: The role of perceived green-rinsing, influencer type, and sustainability solutions. *Journal of Sustainable Tourism* (ABDC A; Q1).

Accepted manuscript included at the end of this application file.

Writing Sample 2 — Published Article

Cao, T. T., Prentice, C., Wang, Q., & Nguyen, S. (2025). Financial self-discrepancy, consumer well-being, and luxury preferences: The moderating effect of access-based luxury formats. *Psychology & Marketing*, 43, 357–373. doi.org/10.1002/mar.70057 

Published article included at the end of this application file.

Evidence of Teaching Performance

Student teaching evaluations from Hoa Sen University provide evidence of consistently strong teaching performance. Recent evaluations include an overall average of **4.97/5.00** for course and instructor-related criteria. Across multiple classes, my teaching performance was also classified as **Grade A**.

The following pages contain the original teaching evaluation reports issued by Hoa Sen University. The reports are in Vietnamese; key results are summarised above.

BÁO CÁO ĐÁNH GIÁ HIỆU QUẢ MÔN HỌC CỦA SINH VIÊN

Mã giảng viên: 04200

Tên giảng viên: Cao Nhật Tuấn

Học kì: 2532

Mã môn học: PR402DV01

Tỉ lệ % feedback: 50,00%

Số hiệu lớp: 1418

Nội dung đánh giá		Tỉ lệ đánh giá theo thang điểm					Điểm trung bình
Về môn học và tài liệu giảng dạy		Điểm 1	Điểm 2	Điểm 3	Điểm 4	Điểm 5	
1	Chuẩn đầu ra của học phần phù hợp, đáp ứng mục tiêu học phần.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	5,56%	94,44%	4,94
2	Phương pháp kiểm tra, đánh giá học phần rõ ràng và được công khai đến sinh viên.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	100,00%	5,00
3	Nội dung và thời lượng của học phần thiết kế hợp lý.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	5,56%	94,44%	4,94
4	Giáo trình/tài liệu học tập đầy đủ, đa dạng, đáp ứng yêu cầu nội dung của học phần.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	100,00%	5,00
Trung bình cộng							4,97
Về giảng viên		Điểm 1	Điểm 2	Điểm 3	Điểm 4	Điểm 5	
5	Giảng viên cung cấp nhiều kiến thức liên quan đến học phần giảng dạy.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	5,56%	94,44%	4,94
6	Giảng viên có phương pháp truyền đạt nội dung khoa học, rõ ràng, dễ hiểu.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	100,00%	5,00
7	Giảng viên tạo cơ hội cho sinh viên được phát huy năng lực cá nhân, khả năng tự học và chủ động trong các hoạt động học tập.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	100,00%	5,00
8	Giảng viên khách quan, chính xác trong việc đánh giá năng lực và kết quả học tập của sinh viên.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	5,56%	94,44%	4,94
9	Giảng viên phản hồi về kiểm tra, đánh giá giúp sinh viên cải thiện chất lượng học tập.	0,00%	0,00%	0,00%	5,56%	94,44%	4,94
Trung bình cộng							4,97

BÁO CÁO TỔNG HỢP FEEDBACK CỦA TỪNG GIẢNG VIÊN

Học kì: 2533 Mã GV: 04200 Tên GV: Cao Nhật Tuấn

STT	Học kì	Hệ	Khoa	Bộ môn	Mã số GV	Tên GV	Số hiệu lớp	Mã môn học	Tên môn học	SLSV feedback	Sĩ số lớp	Tỉ lệ % feedback	ĐTB môn học và tài liệu GD	ĐTB hoạt động GD của GV	Xếp loại hoạt động GD của GV	Ghi chú
1	2533	DH	MKTT	QHCC	04200	Cao Nhật Tuấn	1212	PR201DE01	Business & Mngt Fundamentals	14	23	60,87%	5,00	4,89	A	
2	2533	DH	MKTT	QHCC	04200	Cao Nhật Tuấn	1213	PR201DE01	Business & Mngt Fundamentals	11	13	84,62%	4,91	4,91	A	
3	2533	DH	MKTT	QHCC	04200	Cao Nhật Tuấn	1214	PR201DE01	Business & Mngt Fundamentals	8	32	25,00%	4,91	4,90	A	
4	2533	DH	MKTT	QTCNT	04200	Cao Nhật Tuấn	1999	TT301DV02	Nghiên cứu thị hiếu KTG	10	40	25,00%	4,90	4,86	A	
5	2533	DH	MKTT	QTCNT	04200	Cao Nhật Tuấn	2000	TT301DV02	Nghiên cứu thị hiếu KTG	8	46	17,39%	4,47	4,48	A	



The Council of the University of Southern Queensland confers on

Nhat Tuan Cao

who has passed all examinations and fulfilled
all prescribed conditions, the award of

DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY

Conferred under a Cotutelle arrangement between
the University of Southern Queensland and
Ho Chi Minh City Open University

Dated this thirty-first day of August 2026

Chancellor



University Secretary

Vice-Chancellor

How Hotels Communicate Sustainability Goal Revisions: The Role of Perceived Green-rinsing, Influencer Type, and Sustainability Solutions

Abstract

This research examines how sustainability goal revisions influence consumer responses in hospitality contexts. Drawing on Attribution Theory, it conceptualizes perceived green-rinsing as consumers' interpretation that revised sustainability goals reflect a retreat from prior commitments for strategic reasons. Across five studies ($N = 1374$ participants), the results show that changing sustainability goals increase perceived green-rinsing and reduce booking intention. This negative effect is weaker when sustainability messages are delivered by influencers rather than by the brand, especially when the influencer is human. The effectiveness of influencer communication also depends on its fit with the sustainability solution type. When influencer-solution fit is present, perceived green-rinsing remains comparatively low for both stable and changing goals, whereas misfit amplifies negative reactions to sustainability goal revisions. The findings offer guidance for communicating sustainability goal changes without undermining booking intention.

Keywords: Hotel sustainability, Green-rinsing, Influencer type, Message source, Sustainability solutions

1. Introduction

Sustainability commitments in hospitality are increasingly expected to evolve over time rather than remain fixed promises. Greenwashing, defined as a discrepancy between sustainability claims and actual performance (Bernini et al., 2024; Gatti et al., 2021), remains a well-recognized problem because it undermines authenticity (Chua et al., 2024), credibility (Chen et al., 2019), trust (Majeed & Kim, 2023), and booking intention (Lv et al., 2024), while exposing hotels to reputational risks (Ding et al., 2026). Consumers view hotels engaged in greenwashing as opportunistic, irresponsible, or deceptive (Chen et al., 2019; Gatti et al., 2021). [Evolving regulatory and reporting requirements compel hotel brands to update their sustainability commitments over time](#) (Chan et al., 2017; Font & McCabe, 2017), such as the European Union's Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive, which promotes accountability, transparency, and measurable progress. Hence, sustainability goal revision [has become](#) a common management practice.

However, not all hospitality brands revise sustainability commitments to reflect genuine environmental progress, a phenomenon that receives limited scholarly attention. Some announce ambitious sustainability goals to attract investors (Hicks, 2025), reduce public scrutiny during sensitive periods (Hicks, 2025), strengthen competitive positioning (Chua et al., 2024), or enhance organizational legitimacy (Font & McCabe, 2017). When these pressures diminish, they may lower targets, extend implementation timelines, or redefine sustainability goals (Huang et al., 2024), retaining reputational benefits while reducing the costs of meeting their original commitments (Ding et al., 2026). Others revise sustainability goals in response to operational constraints, financial limitations, climate change, or consumers' reluctance to adopt sustainable practices during their stays (Halpern & Mwesiumo, 2025; Steiger et al., 2025). Existing greenwashing research rarely distinguishes between opportunistic and legitimate revisions (Golob et al., 2023; Huang et al., 2024), leaving little understanding of how consumers respond when sustainability goals change over time.

To address this gap, this research proposes that sustainability goal revisions may give rise to perceived green-rinsing. Unlike greenwashing, perceived green-rinsing refers to consumers' perception that revised sustainability goals are inconsistent with prior commitments and reflect strategic reputational motives rather than legitimate environmental adaptation (Huang et al., 2024). For example, Coca-Cola revised its recycling targets in 2020 and again in 2022, raising public

doubts about its sincerity. Because consumers cannot directly observe the motives behind such revisions, they may infer whether they reflect strategic dilution or genuine environmental adaptation. Accordingly, this research has three objectives: (RO1) examine how consumers interpret sustainability goal revisions in hospitality, (RO2) investigate how perceived green-rinsing influences booking intention, and (RO3) identify when consumers are more or less likely to infer green-rinsing following these revisions.

This research draws on Attribution Theory (Kelley & Michela, 1980), which proposes that consumers explain actions by inferring their causes, including whether they are internal or external, stable or temporary, and controllable or uncontrollable (Chan, 2025). When hospitality brands revise previously announced sustainability goals without explanation, consumers may attribute the change to strategic motives rather than genuine environmental adaptation, increasing perceived green-rinsing and reducing booking intention. Attribution Theory also suggests that consumers' judgments depend on the information available when evaluating an action (Kelley & Michela, 1980). Accordingly, we propose that message source, influencer type, and influencer-solution fit provide attributional cues that shape how consumers interpret sustainability goal revisions. These cues may influence whether consumers attribute sustainability goal revisions to strategic reputational motives or to more genuine organizational intentions. Message source determines whether the brand communicates directly or through an external party. Influencer type influences the degree of independence consumers attribute to that communicator. Influencer-solution fit shapes whether the communication appears credible or strategically constructed. This framework is relevant in hospitality settings, where sustainability initiatives range from nature-based to technology-based solutions and are communicated through a variety of spokespersons and influencers (Gunduz Songur et al., 2023; Han et al., 2020).

This research makes two contributions. First, it conceptualizes perceived green-rinsing as a consumer-level attribution arising from talk-talk discrepancies in sustainability communication. Second, it extends Attribution Theory by showing that message source, influencer type, and influencer-solution fit represent related communication cues that condition perceived green-rinsing.

2. Literature review

2.1. Greenwashing and perceived green-rinsing

Greenwashing refers to the discrepancy between a brand's sustainability claims and its actual environmental performance (Bernini et al., 2024; Gatti et al., 2021). Early research conceptualized greenwashing as a talk-walk discrepancy, where “talk” refers to sustainability messages and “walk” to the environmental outcomes supporting those claims (Font et al., 2012; Pizzetti et al., 2021; Wickert et al., 2016). Consumers therefore perceive hospitality brands as engaging in greenwashing when sustainability communication exceeds or misrepresents actual outcomes (Font et al., 2012; Wickert et al., 2016). As greenwashing encompasses different forms of sustainability misrepresentation (Font & McCabe, 2017; Peng & Chen, 2019), recent research distinguishes subtypes such as greenhushing and green-rinsing (Huang et al., 2024).

By contrast, perceived green-rinsing refers to consumers' perception that sustainability goal revisions reflect a strategic retreat from prior commitments. It arises from a perceived talk-talk discrepancy in sustainability communication, whereby revised sustainability goals are viewed as inconsistent with earlier commitments (Huang et al., 2024; Pizzetti et al., 2021). Unlike greenwashing, which involves a discrepancy between sustainability claims and actual performance, perceived green-rinsing involves a discrepancy between previously communicated sustainability goals and subsequently revised goals. Sustainability goal revisions do not inherently imply deception because they may reflect legitimate operational constraints, financial limitations, or environmental uncertainty (Halpern & Mwesiumo, 2025; Steiger et al., 2025). Perceived green-rinsing emerges when consumers interpret sustainability revisions as reflecting reputational management rather than genuine environmental adaptation (Hicks, 2025). Perceived green-rinsing integrates two consumer-level components: discrepancy detection, namely the perception that revised goals are inconsistent with prior commitments, and motive attribution, namely the inference that such inconsistency reflects reputational motives rather than genuine environmental adaptation. As consumers increasingly distrust brands' sustainability commitments (Deloitte, 2023), this research investigates how perceived green-rinsing influences booking intention.

2.2. Attribution Theory

Attribution Theory (Kelley & Michela, 1980) explains how consumers evaluate brands' actions by inferring their underlying motives. When a brand's actions appear ambiguous or inconsistent,

consumers determine whether they reflect external constraints or internal motives (Chen et al., 2019; Su et al., 2025). These causal inferences shape evaluations of responsibility, trust, and purchase intentions (Lv et al., 2024; Sim & Kim, 2025). Because sustainability communication is complex and involves multiple stakeholders (Golob et al., 2023), Attribution Theory is widely applied to explain consumer responses to deceptive sustainability practices (Bernini et al., 2024).

Although several constructs appear throughout the hypothesis development, Attribution Theory serves as the primary explanatory framework. Consumers cannot directly observe why sustainability goals are revised; hence, they depend on available cues to infer the motives underlying those revisions. Source credibility, trust, and communicator-solution congruence are conceptualized as attributional cues rather than independent explanatory mechanisms. These cues shape whether consumers interpret a sustainability goal revision as a reasonable response to changing circumstances or as a strategically motivated retreat from prior commitments. Therefore, perceived green-rinsing represents the outcome of this attributional process and serves as the central mechanism linking sustainability goal revisions to booking intention. **Importantly, the communication factors examined in the subsequent hypotheses represent related cues that may shape attributional judgments rather than a single psychological mechanism directly tested in the studies.**

2.3. Human versus Artificial Intelligence-generated influencers

Influencers refer to social media figures who gain fame through sustained online activity (Leung et al., 2022). Influencers are perceived as independent communicators whose content is not fully controlled by the brands they endorse (Boerman et al., 2022). Influencer-generated content can reduce consumers' scepticism toward brand communications and increase message persuasiveness (Leung et al., 2022).

Alongside human influencers, Artificial Intelligence (AI)-generated influencers **are rapidly emerging** as a viable alternative in hospitality marketing (Marti-Ochoa et al., 2025). AI-generated influencers are virtual personas created using computer-generated imagery and generative adversarial networks (GANs) (Campbell et al., 2022). Both human and AI-generated influencers are used in hospitality contexts, including destination promotion, virtual tours, and sustainability communication (Marti-Ochoa et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2026). They are also increasingly employed to promote green products, ethical travel, and pro-environmental behaviours (Boerman et al., 2022;

Marti-Ochoa et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2025). However, evidence regarding the effectiveness of AI-generated versus human influencers remains mixed (Wang et al., 2025).

Although AI-generated influencers resemble humans in appearance and communication style, they differ from human influencers in ways that may influence consumers' attributional judgments (Lou et al., 2023). First, human influencers gain admiration through authentic self-expression and sustained interaction with followers (Lou et al., 2023; Zhou et al., 2024). By contrast, AI-generated influencers are created through algorithmic design and can be customized to match audience preferences (Campbell et al., 2022), leading consumers to perceive them as less intrinsically motivated. Second, human influencers exercise agency over content creation, partnerships, and personal branding (Lee et al., 2025). Nonetheless, AI-generated influencers operate under the direction of brands or creators and are perceived as more tightly controlled (Lee et al., 2025). Third, human influencers can draw on lived experiences when expressing opinions or values, whereas AI-generated influencers lack physical embodiment and personal experience, which may reduce perceived empathy and benevolence (Campbell et al., 2022).

3. Hypothesis development

The hypotheses developed in this section proceed in two stages. First, H1 and H2 establish that sustainability goal revisions reduce booking intention through perceived green-rinsing. Second, H3-H5 progressively examine related communication cues that may help hospitality brands reduce these negative consumer responses when sustainability goals must be revised. H3 first examines whether revised sustainability goals are more effectively communicated by the hospitality brand or by an influencer. Having proposed influencer communication as a potential strategy, H4 then recognizes that hospitality brands increasingly employ different types of influencers, including both human and AI-generated influencers, and therefore examines whether all influencer types are equally effective in reducing perceived green-rinsing. Finally, H5 extends this logic by proposing that neither human nor AI-generated influencers are inherently superior communicators. Instead, their effectiveness depends on whether the influencer type is congruent with the sustainability solution being communicated.

3.1. Sustainability goal revision and booking intention

Sustainability in the hospitality industry refers to managing operations in ways that meet the needs of current consumers, employees, and other stakeholders without compromising future generations'

access to similar services and experiences (Halpern & Mwesiumo, 2025). Some hospitality brands announce ambitious sustainability targets to attract investors, gain legitimacy, or reduce public scrutiny, and later revise those goals by lowering targets or extending timelines (Chua et al., 2024; Font & McCabe, 2017; Hicks, 2025; Huang et al., 2024). However, such revisions are not inherently deceptive. Hotels face operational and financial constraints, sustainability performance depends partly on consumer participation, and environmental conditions may change over time (Halpern & Mwesiumo, 2025; Steiger et al., 2025). Consequently, sustainability goal revisions may reflect either strategic motives or legitimate adjustment.

According to Attribution Theory, consumers often infer motives when organizational actions are ambiguous (Chen et al., 2019). Sustainability goal revisions may prompt concerns that a hospitality brand is retreating from prior commitments, undermining confidence in its sustainability efforts. Because hospitality services are difficult to evaluate before consumption (Ding et al., 2026; Peng & Chen, 2019), and consumers rely on sustainability communication when making booking decisions (Chua et al., 2024; Golob et al., 2023), changing sustainability goals may reduce booking intention relative to stable sustainability goals.

Hypothesis 1 (H1): *Changing sustainability goals decreases booking intention compared with stable sustainability goals.*

3.2. The role of perceived green-rinsing

This research examines perceived green-rinsing as the mechanism through which sustainability goal revisions influence booking intention. According to Attribution Theory (Kelley & Michela, 1980), sustainability goal revisions create attributional ambiguity because consumers cannot easily determine whether the change reflects strategic motives or legitimate external constraints. Thus, sustainability goal revisions do not inherently constitute perceived green-rinsing; consumers may alternatively interpret such changes as legitimate adaptation. However, such ambiguity heightens suspicion and prompts consumers to infer whether brands' actions are genuinely environmentally motivated (Ding et al., 2026; Sillince et al., 2012). This tendency may be reinforced by scepticism toward corporate sustainability commitments. For example, 57% of consumers report doubts about the credibility of firms' sustainability goals (Deloitte, 2023). In hospitality settings, where sustainability performance is difficult to verify before consumption (Ding et al., 2026; Peng & Chen, 2019), consumers may interpret sustainability goal revisions as [a reputationally motivated](#)

retreat, which this research conceptualizes as perceived green-rinsing (Huang et al., 2024). When sustainability goal revisions trigger perceived green-rinsing, consumers evaluate the brand through a greenwashing schema. Consumers may become uncertain whether sustainability commitments are sincere or driven by self-interest, reducing trust in the brand (Chen et al., 2019). Perceived green-rinsing may also undermine brand authenticity by prompting consumers to question whether the hotel can deliver what it previously promised (Majeed & Kim, 2023).

Hypothesis 2 (H2): *Perceived green-rinsing mediates the relationship between sustainability goal and booking intention, such that changing sustainability goals triggers perceived green-rinsing, which in turn lowers booking intention.*

3.3. The role of message source

Sustainability goal revisions may create ambiguity (Sillince et al., 2012), increasing perceived green-rinsing and reducing booking intention. Drawing on Attribution Theory, the perceived source of a sustainability message can shape the attributional inferences consumers draw about the brand's underlying motives (Kelley & Michela, 1980). Prior research shows that message source influences how consumers assign responsibility and interpret sustainability communication (Song et al., 2026). When sustainability messages are delivered by the brand, consumers may be more likely to attribute them to the brand's own intentions (Chen et al., 2019; Pizzetti et al., 2021). In contrast, influencer-delivered messages may be perceived as reflecting an independent assessment rather than the brand's communication (Wang et al., 2025).

Drawing on Attribution Theory, sustainability messages delivered by the hospitality brand may be interpreted as reflecting the brand's own motives. Consumers recognize that sustainability goals are communicated by the brand, and they are aware that such commitments may serve reputational, competitive, or legitimacy-related objectives (Chua et al., 2024; Hicks, 2025; Majeed & Kim, 2023). As a result, consumers may be more likely to attribute responsibility for any subsequent goal revision directly to the brand when the message is brand-delivered (Chan, 2025). When previously announced sustainability goals are revised, consumers may interpret the change as evidence of inconsistency in the brand's commitment (Gatti et al., 2021). These revisions can make sustainability commitments appear less reliable and increase perceptions that the brand is strategically retreating from prior promises. Consequently, brand-delivered sustainability goal revisions are more likely to trigger perceived green-rinsing.

However, an alternative prediction is that brand-delivered sustainability goal revisions signal transparency and accountability (Font et al., 2012), whereas influencer-delivered revisions signal strategic distancing because influencers may be selected, compensated, or otherwise directed by the brand (Boerman et al., 2022). Under this interpretation, influencer-delivered messages may lead sustainability goal revisions to elicit similar levels of perceived green-rinsing as brand-delivered messages. Attribution Theory does not determine which interpretation should prevail. Instead, it proposes that when organizational motives are ambiguous, consumers rely on available communication cues to infer whether an action reflects self-interested or genuine motives (Yu et al., 2025). Whether consumers interpret influencer-delivered sustainability messages as independent or strategically managed therefore depends on how they construe the message source within the communication context (Boerman et al., 2022).

Past studies suggest that independent influencers are generally perceived as providing authentic evaluations and as being less closely associated with the brand than official brand representatives (Wang et al., 2025). Consistent with this perspective, this research describes the communicator as an independent travel influencer who had recently visited the hotel and was sharing what he had learned about its sustainability commitments, without disclosing sponsorship, compensation, or any formal partnership. Accordingly, the present prediction is limited to contexts in which sponsorship or brand affiliation is not disclosed or otherwise salient. Without cues signaling sponsorship or brand affiliation, consumers have little basis to construe the influencer as brand-directed (Boerman et al., 2022). Under these conditions, when brands communicate sustainability goal revisions directly, consumers may be more likely to attribute the message to self-serving motives (Su et al., 2025). In contrast, influencers are often viewed as more independent communicators whose content reflects personal opinions rather than direct brand instruction (Leung et al., 2022). Accordingly, message source is not expected to alter consumers' recognition that sustainability goals have changed. Instead, it is expected to shape whether they attribute that discrepancy to strategic reputational motives. Because perceived green-rinsing arises when consumers detect a discrepancy between previously communicated and revised sustainability goals and attribute it to a reputationally motivated sustainability retreat (Huang et al., 2024; Pizzetti et al., 2021), influencer-delivered messages are expected to weaken this attribution without affecting discrepancy detection. Consequently, influencer-delivered

sustainability messages are expected to elicit lower perceived green-rinsing following sustainability goal revisions than brand-delivered messages.

Hypothesis 3 (H3): *Message source moderates the effect of sustainability goals on perceived green-rinsing. When the messages are delivered by the hospitality brand, changing sustainability goals lead to higher perceived green-rinsing than stable sustainability goals, and, subsequently, lower booking intention. When the message is delivered by an influencer, there will be no difference between changing and stable sustainability goals in terms of perceived green-rinsing, and subsequently booking intention.*

3.4. The role of influencer type

Although influencers can communicate sustainability messages more effectively than hospitality brands, not all influencers shape consumer responses in the same way (Boerman et al., 2022; Franke et al., 2023). Drawing on Attribution Theory, consumers also evaluate whether the communicator appears independent from brand control. When sustainability goals are communicated by human influencers, consumers are less likely to differentiate between stable and changing goals. Human influencers are perceived as more independent from brand control (Lee et al., 2025). As a result, sustainability messages delivered by human influencers are less likely to be attributed to the brand's strategic motives and more likely to be interpreted as reflecting genuine support for sustainability initiatives (Lou et al., 2023; Zhou et al., 2024). These attributions reduce suspicion when sustainability goals are revised and make such revisions appear more acceptable (Lee et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2025). Consequently, perceived green-rinsing is less likely to differ between stable and changing sustainability goals when the message is delivered by a human influencer.

When sustainability goals are communicated by AI-generated influencers, consumers may react more negatively to goal revisions. Because AI-generated influencers are often controlled by sponsoring brands (Lou et al., 2023), their messages tend to be attributed to the brand's intentions. Consumers often view AI-generated influencers as marketing tools rather than independent communicators (Song et al., 2024), which may lead them to infer that the sustainability message reflects the brand's strategic intentions. **As a result, sustainability goal revisions communicated by AI-generated influencers may be interpreted as deliberate and avoidable actions by the hospitality brand.** These **interpretations may** strengthen perceptions of strategic manipulation and increase

perceived green-rinsing (Campbell et al., 2022; Franke et al., 2023; Wang et al., 2025). Consequently, the difference in perceived green-rinsing between stable and changing sustainability goals is expected to be greater when messages are delivered by AI-generated influencers, leading to lower booking intention.

Hypothesis 4 (H4): *Influencer type moderates the effect of sustainability goals on perceived green-rinsing. When the influencer is human, perceived green-rinsing does not differ significantly between stable and changing sustainability goals, resulting in similar levels of booking intention. However, when the influencer is AI, changing goals trigger the strongest increase in perceived green-rinsing, which in turn lowers booking intention.*

3.5. The role of sustainability solution type

The preceding hypotheses focus on the communicator as an attributional cue. However, consumers do not evaluate communicators in isolation; they also evaluate whether the communicator is appropriate for the sustainability solution being promoted (Boerman et al., 2022). Accordingly, AI-generated influencers may be perceived as having closer ties to the brand while also being more appropriate for communicating technology-based sustainability solutions. The latter becomes more salient when consumers evaluate communicator-solution congruence. Therefore, this theorizing does not propose sustainability solution type as a standalone moderator of the goal-revision effect. Instead, it identifies communicator-solution congruence as the relevant attributional cue. Nature-based and technology-based solutions may both provide legitimate bases for revising sustainability goals (Gunduz Songur et al., 2023; Sohaib et al., 2022), but their meaning depends on who communicates them. Accordingly, sustainability solution type provides contextual cues that consumers interpret alongside the communicator when evaluating sustainability goal revisions.

Sustainability communication depends on both the message source and the type of sustainability solution being promoted (Song et al., 2026). Sustainability solution type refers to the primary approach a brand uses to achieve its sustainability goals and can be categorized as nature-based or technology-based (Chan et al., 2017; Han et al., 2020; Steiger et al., 2025). Nature-based solutions rely on natural elements, such as green spaces and surrounding environments (Sohaib et al., 2022). Technology-based solutions rely on technological systems, including energy-efficient equipment and digital monitoring tools, to reduce environmental impact and improve operational

efficiency (Chan et al., 2017). Different sustainability solution types convey different signals about a brand's sustainability efforts (Chan et al., 2017; Gunduz Songur et al., 2023). As a result, they become contextual factors that shape how consumers interpret sustainability goals and subsequent revisions. Consumers evaluate whether the communicator is appropriate for the sustainability solution being promoted. These evaluations influence whether sustainability goal revisions are attributed to legitimate adaptation or to strategic motives. Accordingly, sustainability solution type may shape the extent to which revised goals are perceived as green-rinsing.

Influencer type and sustainability solution type may jointly shape how consumers interpret sustainability goal revisions. Prior research shows that consumers respond more favorably when communication cues are congruent with one another (Wang et al., 2026). Consistent with the match-up hypothesis (Boerman et al., 2022), congruence between the communicator and the sustainability solution can increase the plausibility of sustainability claims. According to Attribution Theory, this congruence may reduce suspicions about underlying motives and make sustainability goal revisions appear more justifiable. Accordingly, consumers may be less likely to interpret revised sustainability goals as green-rinsing when influencer type and sustainability solution type are aligned. When influencer type aligns with the sustainability solution type, consumers are less likely to question the motives behind sustainability communication (Wang et al., 2026). This congruence reduces attributional ambiguity and makes sustainability goal revisions appear more justified. By contrast, when influencer type and solution type are misaligned, consumers may become more uncertain about the brand's motives. Such uncertainty encourages internal and controllable attributions and increases reliance on greenwashing schemas when evaluating revised goals. Accordingly, the effect of sustainability goal revisions on perceived green-rinsing may depend on the alignment between influencer type and sustainability solution type.

Human influencers fit with nature-based solutions because both are associated with personal experience, human judgment, and environmental concern (Franke et al., 2023; Sohaib et al., 2022; Song et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025). This alignment strengthens the plausibility of sustainability claims and reduces doubts about underlying motives (Boerman et al., 2022). Thus, sustainability goal revisions are more likely to be interpreted as legitimate responses to environmental or

operational constraints rather than as a strategic retreat. When sustainability goals remain stable, the same alignment reinforces perceived consistency, resulting in low perceived green-rinsing.

A similar pattern may occur when AI-generated influencers promote technology-based solutions. Technology-based sustainability systems are perceived as evolving and requiring ongoing adjustment (Gunduz Songur et al., 2023). Consequently, sustainability goal revisions in this context may be interpreted as technical adaptation rather than as a strategic retreat. Because AI-generated influencers are associated with automation and technological systems (Campbell et al., 2022; Franke et al., 2023), consumers may perceive them as a fit with technology-based sustainability solutions. This alignment reduces doubts about the motives underlying sustainability goal revisions and weakens green-rinsing inferences when goals change.

By contrast, when influencer type and sustainability solution type are misaligned, sustainability goal revisions may trigger perceived green-rinsing. When AI-generated influencers promote nature-based solutions, consumers may perceive a weaker connection between the communicator and the sustainability approach (Wang et al., 2026). This misalignment can increase uncertainty about the motives underlying sustainability claims and make goal revisions appear more strategically motivated than they actually are (Lee et al., 2025; Zhou et al., 2024).

Hypothesis 5 (H5): *The effect of sustainability goals on perceived green-rinsing and subsequent booking intention is jointly moderated by influencer type and sustainability solution type. When influencer type fits the sustainability solution type (human–nature-based; AI–technology-based), changing sustainability goals do not increase perceived green-rinsing relative to stable goals, resulting in similar booking intention. When influencer type does not fit the sustainability solution type, changing (vs. stable) sustainability goals increase perceived green-rinsing and reduce booking intention.*

4. Methods

We tested the conceptual framework (Figure 1) across one Implicit Association Test (IAT) and four experiments (Table 1). The studies follow a cumulative theory-building logic. Study 1 provides process-level evidence by examining whether sustainability goal change carries negative implicit moral associations. Study 2 establishes the proposed effect of sustainability goal change on booking intention and tests perceived green-rinsing as the underlying mechanism. Study 3

examines whether message source attenuates or amplifies this effect. Study 4 refines this boundary condition by distinguishing between human and AI-generated influencers. Finally, Study 5 adopts a fit-based perspective by examining whether the effectiveness of influencer communication depends on the alignment between influencer type and sustainability solution type. Together, the studies provide convergent evidence for the proposed framework across implicit, mediational, and moderated processes. Different fictitious hotel names were used across studies to avoid carryover effects and minimize brand-specific associations that could confound responses to the sustainability manipulations.

[Figure 1 is here]

Sample sizes for Studies 2-5 were determined using G*Power (Faul et al., 2009). Study 1 employed a laboratory-based Implicit Association Test with participants recruited from a large university in Eastern China. Studies 2-5 recruited U.S. participants through Prolific. Across studies, participants who failed attention checks were excluded and replaced to achieve the targeted final sample size (see Table 1). Confirmatory Factor Analyses are reported in Appendices C, D, and E. Covariates were selected according to each study's design and focal analysis. In Study 2, prior sustainable-hotel use was included in the MANCOVA as a general control but omitted from the mediation model because it was not central to the proposed mechanism. Study 5 retained only environmental concern and green scepticism as covariates for the focal three-way interaction because they were the controls most directly relevant to sustainability judgments.

[Table 1 is here]

5. Study 1

Before testing H1-H5, a supplementary Implicit Association Test (IAT; $N = 120$) examined whether consumers automatically associate changing (vs. stable) sustainability goals with negative evaluations of commitment reliability. Study 1 was not designed to assess perceived green-rinsing directly. Instead, it examined whether goal change functions as an antecedent-level signal that a commitment is less dependable, thereby making later green-rinsing inferences psychologically plausible. Because the IAT captures automatic rather than deliberative evaluations, its findings are less likely to be shaped by cultural norms or institutional trust. Although the stimuli were not hospitality-specific, they capture domain-general associations that precede context-specific

judgments. Results showed a strong implicit association between changing goals and unreliability, and between stable goals and trustworthiness ($D = .551$, $t = 15.394$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.405$). Full details of Study 1 are reported in Appendix F[a].

6. Study 2

6.1. Experiment design, stimuli, and measures

Two hundred and ten participants (58% female, $M_{age} = 32$, 91% holding a bachelor's degree or above, 86% employed full-time, 52% earning \$30,000-\$79,999 annually) were randomly assigned to one of the three experimental conditions. Before exposure to the experimental stimulus, participants completed measures of green knowledge ($\alpha = .890$), environmental concern ($\alpha = .876$), green scepticism ($\alpha = .908$), and prior use of environmentally sustainable hotels. Participants were then asked to imagine browsing accommodation options online and encountering a hotel named Lumina. On the hotel's landing page, they viewed a section titled "Our Sustainability Goals." In the stable goal condition, the hotel maintained its previously announced sustainability targets. In the changing goal condition, the hotel revised its targets by reducing the magnitude of its commitments and extending the timeline for achievement. In the control condition, the hotel expressed a general commitment to sustainability without providing temporal goal information (see Appendix B[a] for the full stimuli).

Following exposure to the stimulus, participants completed measures of perceived sustainability goals, perceived green-rinsing ($\alpha = .865$), booking intention ($\alpha = .863$), perceived greenwashing ($\alpha = .902$), ethical wrongness ($\alpha = .860$), and perceived incompetence ($\alpha = .887$) (Appendix A). Perceived green-rinsing was measured with three items capturing both perceived inconsistency between current and prior sustainability goals and inferences about the motives underlying such revisions (Gatti et al., 2021). One item assessed perceived inconsistency, whereas the remaining two assessed whether participants viewed the revisions as reputation-driven. These items are conceptually distinct from the perceived greenwashing scale, which assesses discrepancies between sustainability claims and actual environmental performance. These constructs were also empirically distinct, as the correlation between perceived green-rinsing and perceived greenwashing in Study 2 ($r = .376$) was well below the square roots of the AVEs for both constructs (.831 and .838), satisfying the Fornell-Larcker criterion.

6.2. Results

6.2.1. Manipulation check

A chi-square test confirmed the effectiveness of the sustainability goal framing manipulation ($p < .001$); most participants correctly identified their assigned goal condition (see Appendix F[b]).

6.2.2. The direct effect of sustainability goals

A one-way MANCOVA examined the effect of sustainability goal framing (control, stable goal, and changing goal) on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention while controlling for green knowledge, environmental concern, green scepticism, and prior use of environmentally sustainable hotels. The multivariate effect was significant, $F(4, 406) = 10.740, p < .001, \eta^2 = .096$.

Follow-up univariate tests showed significant effects of sustainability goal framing on perceived green-rinsing, $F(2, 203) = 22.607, p < .001, \eta^2 = .182$, and booking intention, $F(2, 203) = 12.981, p < .001, \eta^2 = .113$. Bonferroni comparisons showed that the changing goal condition produced higher perceived green-rinsing and lower booking intention than both the stable and control conditions (both $ps < .001$), whereas the stable and control conditions did not differ from each other (both $ps > .42$; Figure 2; see Appendix F[b]).

[Figure 2 is here]

6.2.3. The mediating effect of perceived green-rinsing

To test H2, the control condition was excluded because it did not provide temporal goal information and could not test the consequences of goal change relative to goal stability. We estimated a mediation model using PROCESS Model 4 (Hayes, 2018), with sustainability goal framing (stable goal = 0, changing goal = 1) as the independent variable, perceived green-rinsing as the mediator, booking intention as the dependent variable, and green knowledge, environmental concern, and green scepticism as covariates. The indirect effect of sustainability goal framing on booking intention through perceived green-rinsing was significant ($b = -.610, SE = .175, 95\% CI [-.982, -.301]$). After perceived green-rinsing was included in the model, the direct effect of sustainability goal framing was no longer significant ($b = -.105, SE = .145, t = -.726, p = .467, 95\% CI [-.393, .182]$), [providing initial support for H2](#) (see Table 2).

[Table 2 is here]

As an additional robustness check, we re-estimated the mediation model using only the two motive-attribution items of perceived green-rinsing (PG_1 and PG_2), excluding the discrepancy-detection item (PG_3). The indirect effect remained significant, indicating that the mediation was not dependent on the discrepancy-detection component of the measure. We also repeated the mediation analysis using dummy coding for all three conditions, as expected. Only the changing-goal condition significantly increased perceived green-rinsing relative to the neutral baseline and indirectly reduced booking intention. Full results are reported in Appendix F[b].

6.2.4. Testing alternative explanations

We tested three alternative mediators: perceived greenwashing, ethical wrongness, and perceived incompetence. None of the alternative mediators showed a significant indirect effect (see Appendix F[b]).

7. Study 3

7.1. Experiment design, stimuli, and measures

Study 3 recruited 280 U.S. participants (58% female, $M_{\text{age}} = 32$, 89% holding a bachelor's degree or above, 83% employed full-time, 51% earning \$30,000-\$79,999 annually) to participate in a 2 (sustainability goal: stable vs. changing) $\times$ 2 (message source: hotel spokesperson vs. independent travel influencer) randomized between-subjects experimental design. As in Study 2, participants completed baseline measures of environmental concern ($\alpha = .856$), green scepticism ($\alpha = .898$), green knowledge ($\alpha = .871$), and prior usage of environmentally sustainable hotels.

Participants were instructed to imagine browsing accommodation options online and encountering information about a hotel named Bellmere Hotel. They viewed a sustainability message followed by a video featuring Jabari (see Appendix B[b]). Sustainability goal framing was manipulated in the message shown before the video. In the hotel spokesperson condition, Jabari was introduced as Bellmere Hotel's official spokesperson sharing information about the hotel's sustainability commitments. In the independent travel influencer condition, he was introduced as an independent travel influencer who had recently visited the hotel and was sharing what he had learned about the hotel's sustainability commitments. Participants then viewed a video of Jabari presenting one of the hotel rooms. To isolate message source, the presenter, video, script, and room visuals were held constant across conditions, with only the role-identifying language

varying (Appendix B[b]). After viewing the video, participants completed measures of perceived message source, perceived sustainability goals, perceived green-rinsing ($\alpha = .870$), booking intention ($\alpha = .919$), and demographic characteristics.

7.2. Results

7.2.1. Manipulation check

Two chi-square tests confirmed the effectiveness of both manipulations (both $ps < .001$; see Appendix F[c] for detailed results).

7.2.2. The moderating effect of message source

A one-way MANCOVA examined the effects of sustainability goal framing, message source, and their interaction on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention while controlling for green knowledge, environmental concern, green scepticism, and prior use of environmentally sustainable hotels. The multivariate interaction between sustainability goal framing and message source was significant, $F(2, 271) = 16.417, p < .001, \eta p^2 = .108$. Univariate analyses showed significant interaction effects on perceived green-rinsing, $F(1, 272) = 29.484, p < .001, \eta p^2 = .098$, and booking intention, $F(1, 272) = 24.314, p < .001, \eta p^2 = .082$ (see Figure 3).

[Figure 3 is here]

7.2.3. The moderated mediating effect

To test H3, we estimated a PROCESS Model 7 (Hayes, 2018) with sustainability goal framing (stable = 0, changing = 1) as the independent variable, perceived green-rinsing as the mediator, booking intention as the dependent variable, and message source (hotel spokesperson = 0, independent travel influencer = 1) as the moderator. Green knowledge, environmental concern, green scepticism, and prior use of environmentally sustainable hotels were included as covariates. The interaction between sustainability goal framing and message source significantly predicted perceived green-rinsing ($b = -1.418, SE = .261, t = -5.430, p < .001, 95\% CI [-1.933, -.904]$) (see Table 3). The moderated mediation pattern remained substantively unchanged when perceived green-rinsing was operationalized using only the two motive-attribution items (see Appendix F[c]).

[Table 3 is here]

8. Study 4

8.1. Experimental design, stimuli, and measures

Study 4 recruited 280 U.S. participants (61% female, $M_{\text{age}} = 31$, 92% holding a bachelor's degree or above, 81% employed full-time, and 51% earning \$30,000-\$79,999 annually) to participate in a 2 (sustainability goal: stable vs. changing) $\times$ 2 (influencer type: human vs. AI-generated) randomized between-subjects design. Consistent with Studies 2 and 3, participants completed measures of green knowledge ($\alpha = .889$), prior use of environmentally sustainable hotels, distrust of AI-generated influencers ($\alpha = .938$), technology acceptance ($\alpha = .771$), environmental concern ($\alpha = .873$), and green scepticism ($\alpha = .939$) before exposure to the experimental stimuli.

Following the procedure used in Study 3, participants viewed a social media post and promotional video featuring a Caucasian, young, female influencer named Mary discussing Aurelia Cove Hotel (Appendix B[c]). Regarding sustainability goal manipulations, the stable condition described the hotel as maintaining its sustainability commitments over time, whereas the changing condition described the hotel as lowering its original target and extending the timeline for achieving its goals, and influencer type was manipulated by identifying Mary as either a human influencer or an AI-generated virtual influencer. The video, visual appearance, hotel footage, and promotional content were held constant across conditions. After exposure, participants completed measures of perceived influencer type, perceived sustainability goals, perceived green-rinsing ($\alpha = .863$), and booking intention ($\alpha = .919$).

8.2. Results

8.2.1. Manipulation check

Two chi-square tests confirmed the effectiveness of both manipulations (both $ps < .001$; see Appendix F[d]).

8.2.2. The interaction effect of sustainability goal framing and influencer type

A one-way MANCOVA was conducted to examine the effects of sustainability goal framing, influencer type, and their interaction on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention, while controlling for green knowledge, distrust of AI-generated influencers, environmental concern, green scepticism, technology acceptance, and prior usage of environmentally sustainable hotels. The multivariate interaction between sustainability goal framing and influencer type was

significant ($F(2, 269) = 6.615, p = .002, \eta p^2 = .047$). Follow-up univariate tests showed that the interaction significantly affected perceived green-rinsing ($F(1, 270) = 12.554, p < .001, \eta p^2 = .044$) and booking intention ($F(1, 270) = 5.156, p = .024, \eta p^2 = .019$; see Figure 4).

[Figure 4 is here]

8.2.3. The moderating effect of influencer type

To test H4, we estimated a PROCESS Model 7 (Hayes, 2018) with sustainability goal framing (stable = 0, changing = 1) as the independent variable, perceived green-rinsing as the mediator, booking intention as the dependent variable, and influencer type (human = 0, AI-generated = 1) as the moderator, using the same covariates as in the preceding MANCOVA. The interaction between sustainability goal framing and influencer type significantly predicted perceived green-rinsing ($b = .854, SE = .241, t = 3.536, p < .001, 95\% CI [.378, 1.329]$) (see Table 4). These effects remained significant after controlling for distrust of AI-generated influencers and technology acceptance. The results were robust to using only the two motive-attribution items of perceived green-rinsing (see Appendix F[d]).

[Table 4 is here]

9. Study 5

9.1. Methods

9.1.1. Experimental design, stimuli, measures, and participants

Study 5 employed a 2 (sustainability goal: stable vs. changing) $\times$ 2 (influencer type: human vs. AI-generated) $\times$ 2 (solution type: nature-based vs. technology-based) randomized between-subjects design. The sample comprised 484 participants (63% female, $M_{age} = 40$, 83% held a bachelor's degree or higher, 55% were employed full-time, and 48% earned \$30,000–\$79,999 annually). Participants imagined viewing a social media post from Benjamin, presented as either a human or AI-generated influencer, promoting Horizon Bay. The post described sustainability commitments that were either maintained or revised. Nature-based solutions emphasized natural materials, plant-supported air freshness, and water-saving fixtures, whereas technology-based solutions emphasized AI-assisted climate control, smart energy optimization, and automated water-efficiency systems. After viewing the post (Appendix B[d]), participants completed measures of perceived solution type, influencer type, perceived sustainability goal, perceived green-rinsing (α

= .849), booking intention ($\alpha = .953$), environmental concern ($\alpha = .891$), green scepticism ($\alpha = .910$), and demographics. All measurement items are reported in Appendix A.

An a priori power analysis using G*Power for the focal three-way interaction in the $2 \times 2 \times 2$ design indicated that a minimum sample size of 210 participants was required to detect an effect of $f = .25$ with 95% power at $\alpha = .05$ (Faul et al., 2009). Because higher-order interactions may be smaller than this conventional medium-effect benchmark, we additionally conducted a sensitivity analysis based on the final sample size of $N = 484$. The study had 80% power to detect a three-way interaction as small as $f = .128$ ($\eta p^2 = .016$), 90% power to detect $f = .148$ ($\eta p^2 = .021$), and 95% power to detect $f = .164$ ($\eta p^2 = .026$).

9.2. Results

9.2.1. Manipulation check

All manipulations were successful (see Appendix F[e]).

9.2.2. The interaction among sustainability goals, influencer type, and solution type

A MANCOVA examined the effects of sustainability goal framing, influencer type, sustainability solution type, and their interactions on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention, controlling for environmental concern and green scepticism. Because Box's M and Levene's tests were significant, Pillai's Trace was used. The multivariate three-way interaction among sustainability goal framing, influencer type, and sustainability solution type was significant ($F(2, 473) = 6.934$, $p = .001$, $\eta p^2 = .028$). Follow-up univariate analyses showed significant three-way interactions for perceived green-rinsing ($F(1, 474) = 7.637$, $p = .006$, $\eta p^2 = .016$) and booking intention ($F(1, 474) = 4.050$, $p = .045$, $\eta p^2 = .008$). Given its modest effect size and proximity to the 80% detectable threshold, the three-way interaction for perceived green-rinsing should be interpreted cautiously. Because H5 primarily concerns a moderated mediation process, we interpret the booking-intention interaction as supportive descriptive evidence and focus the formal test of the proposed mechanism on the moderated mediation analysis reported below (see Figure 5).

[Figure 5]

9.2.3. The moderated moderated mediation effect

To test the moderated mediation predicted in H5, we estimated PROCESS Model 11 (Hayes, 2018), with sustainability goal framing (stable = 0, changing = 1) as the independent variable, perceived

green-rinsing as the mediator, booking intention as the dependent variable, influencer type (human = 0, AI-generated = 1) as the first moderator, and sustainability solution type (nature-based = 0, technology-based = 1) as the second moderator. Environmental concern and green scepticism were included as covariates. As shown in Table 5, the three-way interaction among sustainability goal framing, influencer type, and sustainability solution type significantly predicted perceived green-rinsing ($b = -1.880$, $SE = .510$, $t = -3.682$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-2.883, -.876]$). The conditional effects were consistent with the proposed fit pattern (Table 5). Changing sustainability goals increased perceived green-rinsing only under misfit conditions: AI-generated influencers with nature-based solutions ($b = .948$, $p < .001$) and human influencers with technology-based solutions ($b = .835$, $p = .001$); but not under fit conditions (human-nature: $b = .061$, $p = .808$; AI-technology: $b = -.157$, $p = .538$).

Perceived green-rinsing significantly reduced booking intention ($b = -.465$, $SE = .043$, $t = -10.849$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-.550, -.381]$). The direct effect of sustainability goal framing on booking intention was not significant after perceived green-rinsing was included in the model ($b = -.174$, $SE = .126$, $t = -1.378$, $p = .169$, 95% $CI [-.422, .074]$). Consistent with the proposed fit logic, significant indirect effects emerged only under influencer-solution misfit conditions (human-technology: $b = -.389$; AI-generated–nature: $b = -.441$). The index of moderated moderated mediation was significant (Index = .875, $SE = .250$, 95% $CI [.415, 1.395]$), supporting H5. The moderated moderated mediation pattern also remained robust when perceived green-rinsing was operationalized using only the two motive-attribution items (see Appendix F[e]).

[Table 5 is here]

10. General discussion

This research examined consumer responses to sustainability goal revisions in hospitality, focusing on perceived green-rinsing and the communication conditions that shape these responses when revisions are presented with limited explanation. Study 1 provided process-level evidence that sustainability goal revisions are automatically associated with commitment unreliability, whereas Studies 2-5 showed that they reduced booking intention by increasing perceived green-rinsing. These effects varied according to how the revisions were communicated and who communicated them. Perceived green-rinsing received initial support as the mechanism linking sustainability goal revisions to booking intention, while message source, influencer type, and influencer-solution fit

influenced the extent to which consumers inferred opportunistic motives. The findings suggest that, when the reasons for revision are unclear, consumers evaluate both the sustainability strategy and the communicator delivering the message.

Study 1 provides process-level evidence that sustainability goal temporality carries **reliability-related** meaning. Using an Implicit Association Test, it shows that consumers automatically associate changing goals with unreliability and stable goals with trustworthiness. These associations emerged without brand-specific information or a hospitality context, suggesting that goal change serves as a **negative cue regarding commitment reliability** before consumers evaluate brand motives or message credibility. Study 2 showed that changing sustainability goals presented with limited explanation reduced booking intention through perceived green-rinsing. Under these conditions, consumers interpreted the revisions as strategically motivated rather than genuinely environment-driven, supporting the role of **reliability-related** inference in sustainability communication and showing that scepticism can arise even without explicit deception.

Within the context of unexplained sustainability goal revisions, Study 3 identified message source as a boundary condition. **Revisions elicited stronger perceived green-rinsing and lower booking intention when communicated by the hospitality brand than by an independent influencer without disclosed sponsorship or brand affiliation.** These findings suggest that consumers attribute different levels of accountability and strategic intent to different communicators, allowing influencer-delivered messages to diffuse **perceived brand** responsibility. Study 4 further showed that this effect depended on influencer type. Human influencers reduced the green-rinsing penalty, whereas AI-generated influencers strengthened it. **Within Study 4, AI-generated influencers elicited higher perceived green-rinsing and lower booking intention than human influencers.** Consumers may view AI influencers as extensions of brand-controlled technology rather than independent social actors, making the revisions appear more strategically motivated.

Finally, within the context of unexplained sustainability goal revisions, Study 5 provided **cautious evidence** that consumer responses depended on the fit between influencer type and sustainability solution. When the communicator matched the solution, the revisions did not reduce booking intention. When they were mismatched, green-rinsing perceptions increased and booking intention declined. These findings suggest that consumers evaluate sustainability communication holistically, drawing inferences from the consistency between the communicator and the

sustainability solution. However, because the nature-based and technology-based manipulations may also have conveyed related meanings, the findings should be interpreted as evidence for communicator-solution congruence rather than for the nature-versus-technology distinction alone.

Overall, sustainability goal revisions are not inherently detrimental; their effects depend on communication cues that shape whether consumers infer legitimate adaptation or opportunistic intent. By identifying perceived green-rinsing as the underlying mechanism and showing how message source, influencer type, and influencer-solution fit shape **attributional** inferences, this research provides a framework for understanding consumer responses to sustainability goal revisions.

11. Conclusion

11.1. Theoretical contribution

This research contributes to the sustainability literature by providing an initial conceptualization of perceived green-rinsing as a consumer-level attributional inference. Prior work on greenwashing focuses on consumers detecting discrepancies between sustainability claims and actual performance (Bernini et al., 2024; Gatti et al., 2021; Font et al., 2012; Wickert et al., 2016). By contrast, this research examines how consumers respond to inconsistencies across sustainability goals over time. Perceived green-rinsing emerges when consumers detect a discrepancy between previously communicated and subsequently revised sustainability goals and attribute that discrepancy to a reputationally motivated sustainability retreat. Studies 2-5 provide initial evidence that sustainability goal revisions can trigger negative consumer responses through perceived green-rinsing even in the absence of false performance claims, whereas Study 1 provides antecedent-level evidence that sustainability goal revisions are automatically associated with moral unreliability. By distinguishing between the firm-level act of revising sustainability goals and consumers' attributional interpretations of those revisions, this research offers preliminary evidence toward a more precise account of how perceived green-rinsing develops from these antecedent moral associations in response to temporal inconsistencies in sustainability communication.

Second, this research extends Attribution Theory to temporal sustainability communication by identifying when sustainability goal revisions are more or less likely to generate perceived

green-rinsing. The findings show that sustainability goal revisions function as attributional cues that shape how consumers interpret the motives underlying sustainability goal revisions. The research suggests that communication-related factors influence how these attributional judgments are formed. Message source, influencer type, and influencer-solution fit represent related communication cues that condition perceived green-rinsing rather than a single psychological mechanism directly tested in the studies. The findings provide initial evidence that communicator-solution congruence shapes attributional inferences. However, the nature-based and technology-based operationalizations may also capture related meanings that future research should distinguish. In doing so, the research provides an attributional framework for understanding when sustainability goal revisions may trigger perceived green-rinsing and when they are more likely to be tolerated.

11.2. Managerial implications

This research offers directional implications for hospitality managers communicating sustainability goals under conditions of uncertainty and change. While the findings are derived from controlled experiments, they provide insight into how consumers may interpret sustainability goal revisions and how different communication strategies may shape those interpretations. First, sustainability goal revisions may not be treated as neutral updates. When the reasons for revision are unclear, consumers may attribute them to strategic reputational motives rather than legitimate environmental adaptation. Therefore, managers may consider communicating that sustainability goals have changed, why the change occurred, and how revised goals remain connected to broader sustainability commitments. Transparent explanations may help reduce negative attributions and preserve confidence in the brand's sustainability efforts. Second, message source may influence these interpretations. Communications delivered directly by the brand may activate internal and controllable attributions, whereas messages from independent influencers without disclosed sponsorship or brand affiliation were associated with weaker green-rinsing inferences. Hence, hospitality managers should consider the content of sustainability communications and who delivers them, while recognizing that these findings may not extend to sponsored or brand-affiliated influencers.

Third, influencer type may shape consumer responses to sustainability goal revisions. In this research, human influencers appeared more effective than AI-generated influencers when

communicating revised sustainability commitments, which may reflect consumers' perception that human influencers are more independent from brand control. Although AI-generated influencers offer scalability and operational efficiency (Campbell et al., 2022), hospitality managers should carefully evaluate whether they are the most appropriate communicators for sustainability messages involving revised commitments. Fourth, communication effectiveness may depend on both the communicator and the fit between the communicator and the sustainability solution being promoted. Study 5 provides initial evidence that communicator-solution congruence may shape communication effectiveness. Managers may therefore consider influencer-solution fit as one potential factor in communication decisions rather than focusing exclusively on influencer popularity or reach. Finally, stable sustainability goals consistently generated lower green-rinsing perceptions than revised goals, suggesting the importance of setting realistic sustainability targets from the outset. When revisions are necessary, aligning the message source, influencer type, and sustainability solution may help reduce negative consumer inferences. Whether these effects translate into actual booking behaviour warrants further investigation.

11.3. Limitations and future research directions

Although the studies used realistic stimuli, including hotel landing pages, promotional videos, and social media posts, they were conducted in controlled settings and measured evaluative responses rather than actual booking behaviour. The studies also used fictitious hotel brands and provided limited explanations for sustainability goal revisions. In practice, consumers may receive explanations related to regulatory requirements, operational constraints, or environmental uncertainty, which could change responsibility attributions and reduce perceived green-rinsing. Hotel choices also depend on price, reviews, brand familiarity, and platform recommendations, which may weaken the effect of sustainability goal revisions. Future research could examine these effects using choice-based conjoint designs or field experiments.

Second, this research examined sustainability goal revisions at a general level without distinguishing among sustainability domains. Consumer responses may differ across commitments such as waste reduction, energy efficiency, water conservation, and carbon emissions (Sohaib et al., 2022). In addition, the nature-based and technology-based solution manipulations in Study 5 may have conveyed related meanings, such as tradition, locality, innovation, or novelty. Future research should disentangle these attributes and examine whether different sustainability domains

and solution characteristics differentially influence perceived green-rinsing and booking intention. Given the modest three-way interaction observed in Study 5, replication in more realistic decision environments is also warranted.

Third, Studies 2-5 recruited participants from the United States, whereas Study 1 involved Chinese university students, limiting the generalizability of the findings across cultures. Future research could examine whether cultural factors, such as individualism-collectivism and AI acceptance, shape consumer responses to sustainability goal revisions. The strong correlation between perceived green-rinsing and booking intention in Study 2 ($r = -.780$) also suggests some overlap in evaluative responses, although this association was substantially weaker in Study 5 ($r = -.487$). Finally, this research provides initial evidence for perceived green-rinsing using an adapted greenwashing measure. Although the items captured discrepancy detection and motive attribution, future research should develop and validate a dedicated perceived green-rinsing scale anchored in talk-talk discrepancy and establish its discriminant validity from perceived greenwashing.

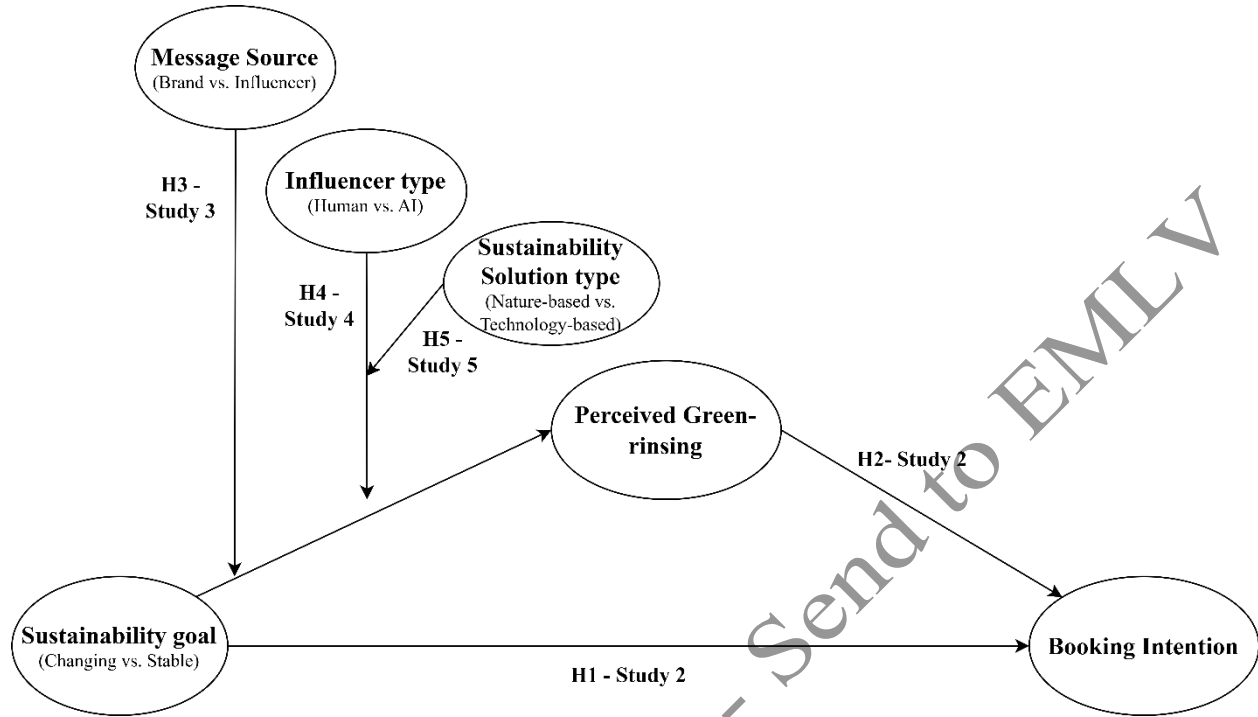
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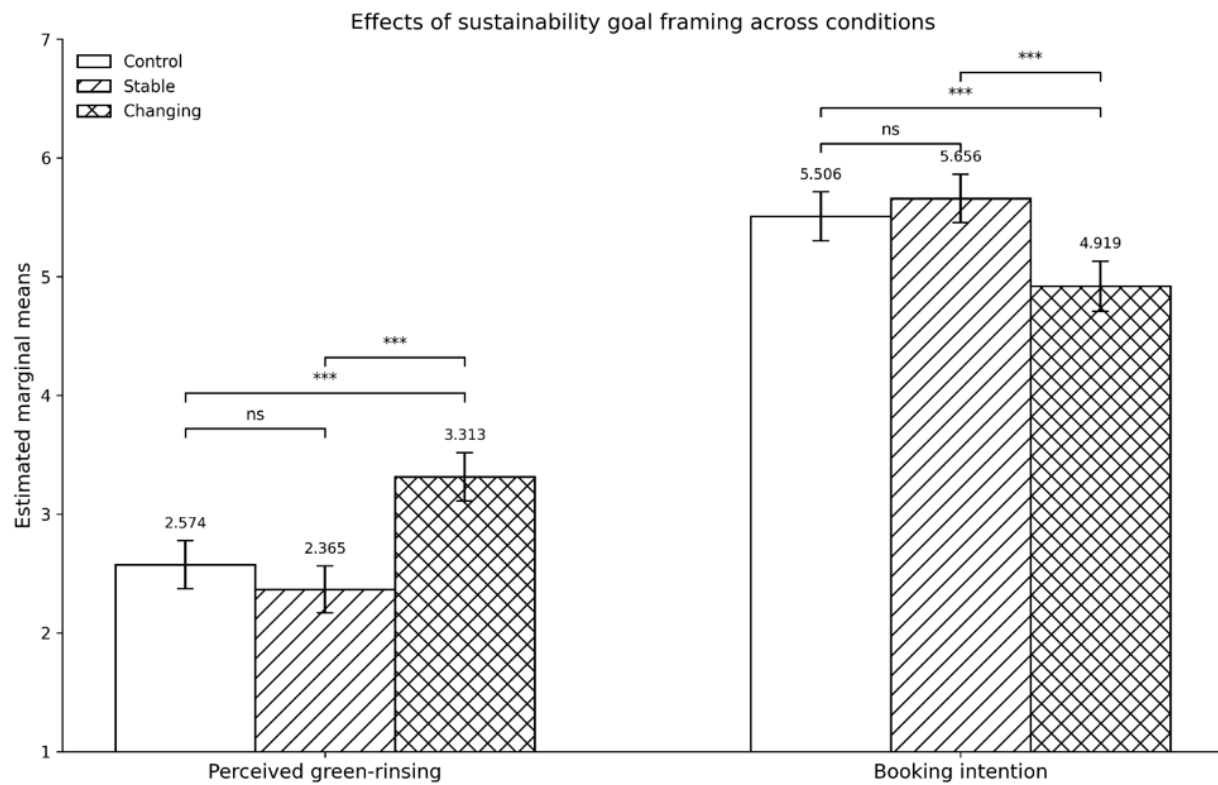
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Note. H3-H5 represent progressively refined moderators of the first-stage path from sustainability goal framing to perceived green-rinsing.

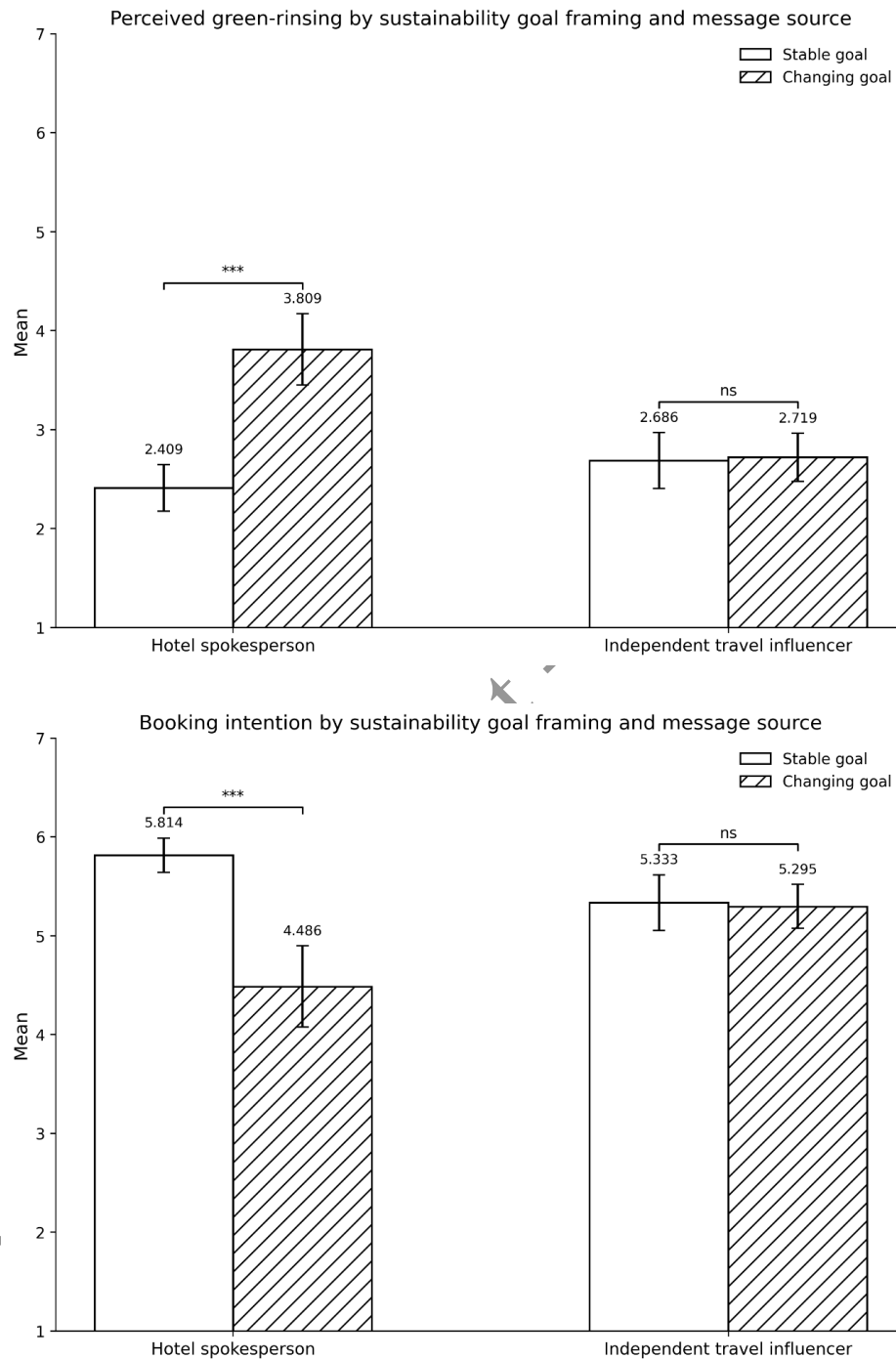
Figure 1. The conceptual model

Figure 2. Effects of sustainability goal framing on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention (Study 2)



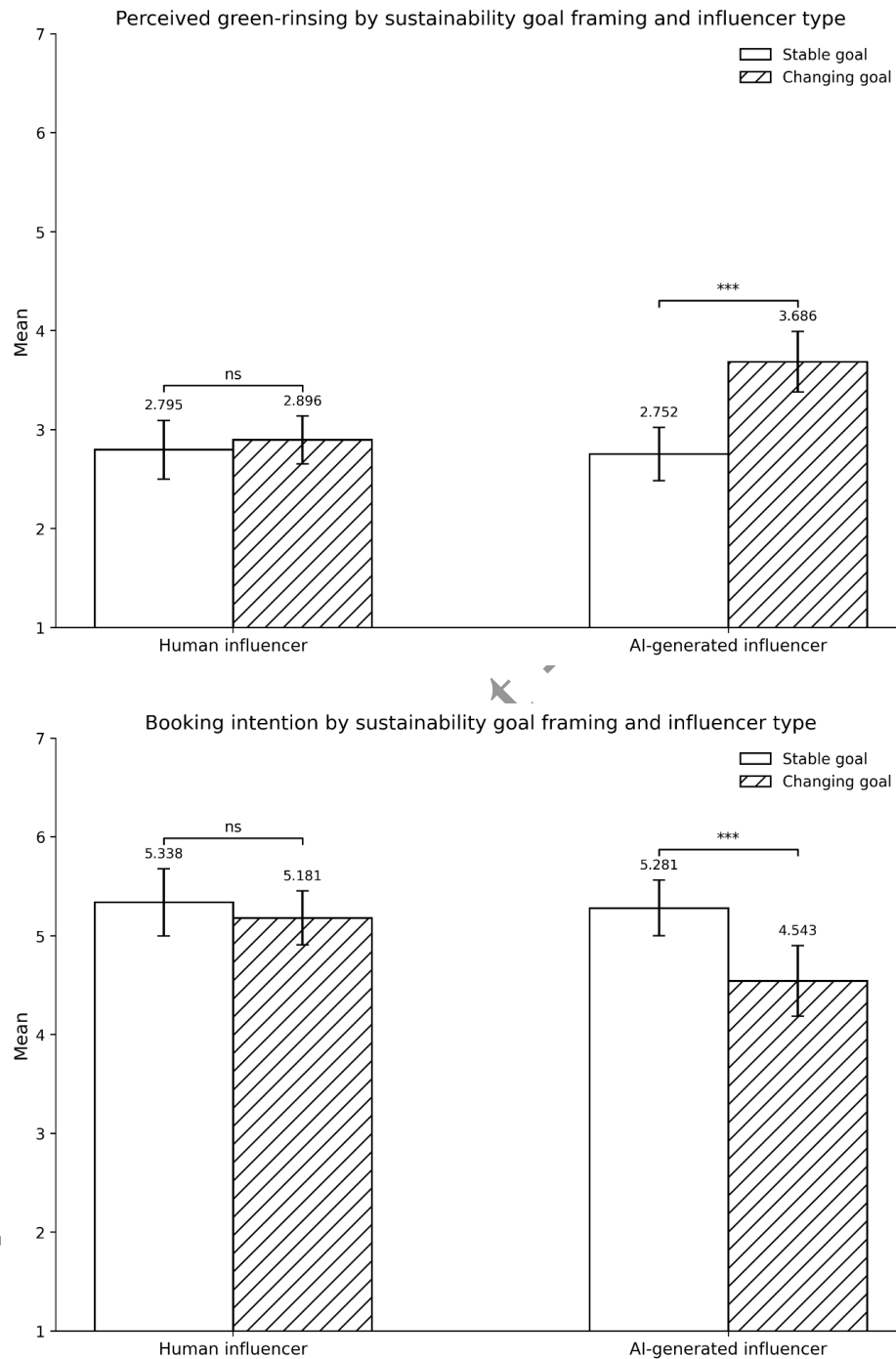
Note. Bars represent estimated marginal means after controlling for covariates. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. *ns* = non-significant; *** $p < .001$.

Figure 3. Effects of sustainability goal framing and message source on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention (Study 3)



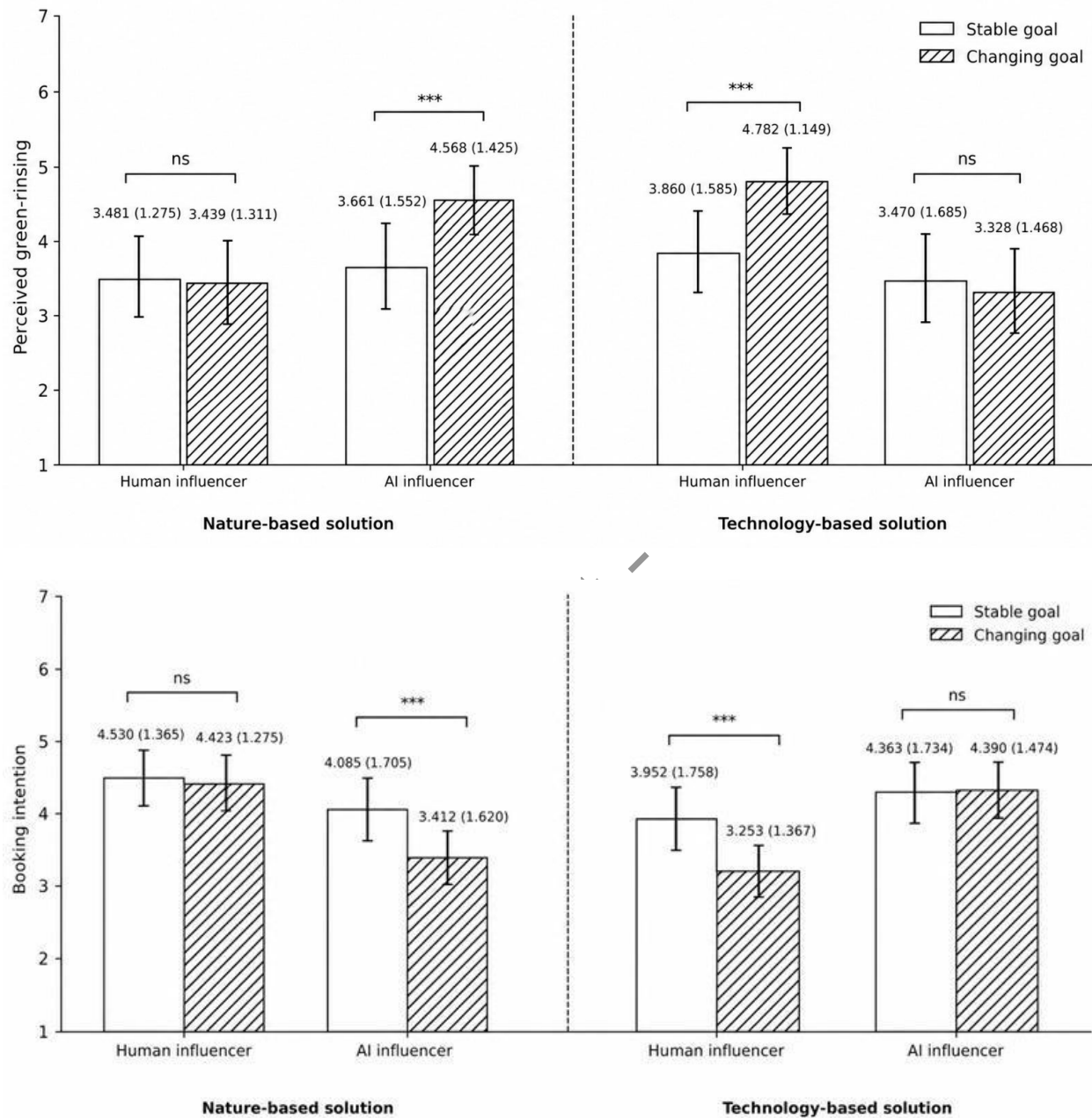
Note. Bars represent raw means. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. *** $p < .001$; ns = non-significant.

Figure 4. Effects of sustainability goal framing and influencer type on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention (Study 4).



Note. Bars represent raw means. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. *** $p < .001$; ns = non-significant.

Figure 5. Effects of sustainability goal framing, influencer type, and sustainability solution type on perceived green-rinsing and booking intention (Study 5).



Note. Bars represent raw means. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. *** $p < .001$; ns = non-significant.

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Table 1. Summary of the five studies

Study	Purpose	Design	Final analytic sample (N)	Attention check failure rate	Power analysis	Stimulus
Pretest	Identify representative stimuli for the IAT categories	Stimulus pretest	50 laboratory participants; China	N/A	N/A	• Sustainability goal words • Trustworthiness/unreliability words
1	Establish implicit association	IAT	120 laboratory participants; China	N/A	N/A	• Sustainability goal words paired with trustworthiness/unreliability attributes
2	H1-H2	3-condition between-subjects	210 US. Prolific	2.3% (5 excluded)	$f = .25$, $\alpha = .05$, power = .80, $N_{min} = 159$	• Lumina Hotel sustainability goals (vignette + photos)
3	H3	2×2 between-subjects	280 US. Prolific	2.4% (7 excluded)	$f = .25$, $\alpha = .05$, power = .95, $N_{min} = 212$	• Bellmere Hotel sustainability message (video + African, old, male spokesperson / influencer manipulation)
4	H4	2×2 between-subjects	280 US. Prolific	1.4% (4 excluded)	$f = .25$, $\alpha = .05$, power = .95, $N_{min} = 212$	• Aurelia Cove influencer post (video + Caucasian, young, female human/AI manipulation)
5	H5	2×2×2 between-subjects	484 US. Prolific	1.4% (7 excluded)	<i>Focal three-way interaction: $f = .25$, $\alpha = .05$, power = .95, $N_{min} = 210$</i> <i>Sensitivity ($N = 484$): $f = .128$ at 80% power; $f = .148$ at 90%; $f = .164$ at 95%</i>	• Horizon Bay sustainability post (human/AI × nature/technology solution)

Table 2. Mediation results (Study 2).

Model	Path a: X → M	Path b: M → Y	Direct effect	Indirect effect	Standardized indirect effect	R ² for mediator model	R ² for outcome model
Without covariates	$b = 1.367, SE = .192, p < .001, 95\% CI [.987, 1.747]$	$b = -.799, SE = .057, p < .001, 95\% CI [-.911, -.687]$	$b = -.042, SE = .149, p = .781, 95\% CI [-.337, .254]$	$b = -1.092, SE = .194, 95\% CI [-1.481, -.721]$	$b = -.836, SE = .117, 95\% CI [-1.068, -.607]$	.268	.670
With covariates	$b = .930, SE = .154, p < .001, 95\% CI [.625, 1.236]$	$b = -.656, SE = .072, p < .001, 95\% CI [-.798, -.513]$	$b = -.105, SE = .145, p = .469, 95\% CI [-.393, .182]$	$b = -.610, SE = .175, 95\% CI [-.982, -.301]$	$b = -.467, SE = .121, 95\% CI [-.720, -.247]$	.584	.704

Note. X = sustainability goal framing; M = perceived green-rinsing; Y = booking intention

Table 3. Moderated mediation results (Study 3)

Model	$X \times W \rightarrow M$	R^2 for mediator model	$M \rightarrow Y$	Direct effect	Indirect effect: brand	Indirect effect: influencer	Index of moderated mediation	R^2 for outcome model
Without covariates	$b = -1.367$, $SE = .292$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-1.941, -.793]$	.164	$b = -.717$, $SE = .041$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-.798, -.636]$	$b = -.170$, $SE = .109$, $p = .120$, 95% $CI [-.383, .044]$	$b = -1.004$, $SE = .190$, 95% $CI [-1.390, -.646]$	$b = -.024$, $SE = .139$, 95% $CI [-.297, .248]$	Index = .980, $SE = .232$, 95% $CI [.535, 1.449]$	0.557
With covariates	$b = -1.418$, $SE = .261$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-1.933, -.904]$	.342	$b = -.672$, $SE = .043$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-.758, -.587]$	$b = -.133$, $SE = .105$, $p = .204$, 95% $CI [-.339, .073]$	$b = -.807$, $SE = .167$, 95% $CI [-1.160, -.509]$	$b = .147$, $SE = .122$, 95% $CI [-.105, .378]$	Index = .953, $SE = .203$, 95% $CI [.572, 1.367]$	0.598

Note. X = sustainability goal framing; W = message source; M = perceived green-rinsing; Y = booking intention.

Table 4. Moderated mediation results (Study 4)

Model	$X \times W \rightarrow M$	R^2 for mediator model	$M \rightarrow Y$	Direct effect	Indirect effect: human	Indirect effect: AI-generated	Index of moderated mediation	R^2 for outcome model
Without covariates	$b = .843$, $SE = .288$, $p = .004$, 95% $CI [.276, 1.410]$	.092	$b = -.683$, $SE = .052$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-.786, -.581]$	$b = -.098$, $SE = .130$, $p = .454$, 95% $CI [-.354, .159]$	$b = -.062$, $SE = .138$, 95% $CI [-.324, .208]$	$b = -.638$, $SE = .162$, 95% $CI [-.968, -.331]$	Index = -.576, $SE = .216$, 95% $CI [-1.023, -.174]$	.402
With covariates	$b = .854$, $SE = .241$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [.378, 1.329]$	.387	$b = -.479$, $SE = .058$, $p < .001$, 95% $CI [-.594, -.364]$	$b = -.139$, $SE = .124$, $p = .265$, 95% $CI [-.382, .105]$	$b = .008$, $SE = .093$, 95% $CI [-.154, .209]$	$b = -.401$, $SE = .107$, 95% $CI [-.626, -.210]$	Index = -.409, $SE = .147$, 95% $CI [-.730, -.153]$	.487

Note. X = sustainability goal framing; W = influencer type; M = perceived green-rinsing; Y = booking intention.

Table 5. The joint moderating effect of influencer type and solution type (Study 5)

Statistical information	With covariates	Without covariates
Mediator model: <i>M</i>		
Model R^2	.168	.116
$X \times W \times Z \rightarrow M$	$b = -1.880, SE = .510, p < .001, 95\% CI [-2.883, -.876]$	$b = -2.012, SE = .524, p < .001, 95\% CI [-3.042, -.983]$
<i>Conditional effect of <i>X</i> on <i>M</i></i>		
$W = 0, Z = 0$	$b = .061, SE = .252, p = .808, 95\% CI [-.434, .556]$	$b = -.042, SE = .258, p = .872, 95\% CI [-.549, .466]$
$W = 0, Z = 1$	$b = .835, SE = .256, p = .001, 95\% CI [.332, 1.339]$	$b = .921, SE = .263, p < .001, 95\% CI [.405, 1.438]$
$W = 1, Z = 0$	$b = .948, SE = .257, p < .001, 95\% CI [.443, 1.453]$	$b = .907, SE = .264, p = .001, 95\% CI [.387, 1.427]$
$W = 1, Z = 1$	$b = -.157, SE = .255, p = .538, 95\% CI [-.659, .344]$	$b = -.142, SE = .262, p = .588, 95\% CI [-.657, .373]$
Outcome model: <i>Y</i>		
Model R^2	.268	.240
$M \rightarrow Y$	$b = -.465, SE = .043, p < .001, 95\% CI [-.550, -.381]$	$b = -.506, SE = .042, p < .001, 95\% CI [-.589, -.423]$
Direct effect of <i>X</i> on <i>Y</i>	$b = -.174, SE = .126, p = .169, 95\% CI [-.422, .074]$	$b = -.151, SE = .128, p = .239, 95\% CI [-.403, .101]$
<i>Conditional indirect effects: $X \rightarrow M \rightarrow Y$</i>		
$W = 0, Z = 0$	$b = -.028, SE = .108, 95\% CI [-.246, .174]$	$b = .021, SE = .121, 95\% CI [-.213, .261]$
$W = 0, Z = 1$	$b = -.389, SE = .117, 95\% CI [-.636, -.164]$	$b = -.466, SE = .139, 95\% CI [-.756, -.206]$
$W = 1, Z = 0$	$b = -.441, SE = .123, 95\% CI [-.684, -.207]$	$b = -.459, SE = .147, 95\% CI [-.756, -.186]$
$W = 1, Z = 1$	$b = .073, SE = .141, 95\% CI [-.200, .350]$	$b = .072, SE = .148, 95\% CI [-.217, .372]$
Index of moderated moderated mediation	Index = .875, $SE = .250, 95\% CI [.415, 1.395]$	Index = 1.019, $SE = .286, 95\% CI [.475, 1.607]$

Note. X = sustainability goal framing; M = perceived green-rinsing; Y = booking intention; W = influencer type; Z = sustainability solution type. X was coded as stable = 0 and changing = 1. W was coded as human influencer = 0 and AI-generated influencer = 1. Z was coded as nature-based solution = 0 and technology-based solution = 1.

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RESEARCH ARTICLE

Financial Self-Discrepancy, Consumer Well-Being, and Luxury Preferences: The Moderating Effect of Access-Based Luxury Formats

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ABSTRACT

This study investigates how the gaps between current financial status and financial aspirations or obligations shape consumer well-being and luxury preferences. Drawing on self-discrepancy and regulatory focus theories, this study uncovers how financial actual–ideal and actual–ought discrepancies activate different compensatory behaviors through consumers' well-being states (eudaimonic vs. hedonic). Eight studies including six experimental and two cross-sectional designs ($N = 1132$) were conducted to test the proposed hypotheses. The results show that financial actual–ideal discrepancies increase, whilst actual–ought discrepancies reduce luxury preference. Eudaimonic well-being mediates the relationship between financial actual–ought discrepancies and luxury preference, while hedonic well-being shows no mediation effect for either self-discrepancy type. The effect of financial actual–ideal discrepancy on luxury preference was moderated by access-based luxury formats, with ideal-discrepant consumers preferring renting and second-hand options over co-ownership. This study contributes to positive psychology and luxury marketing by linking consumers' financial status, well-being, and luxury preference. This study also provides managerial guidance on aligning campaign timing strategies with consumers' financial self-discrepancies and highlights societal implications for fostering inclusivity and addressing ethical concerns in luxury preference.

1 | Introduction

Despite ongoing economic uncertainty following the COVID-19 pandemic, the global luxury market rebounded from \$338.14 billion in 2020 to \$473.93 billion in 2024 (Statista 2024). While financial strain can suppress luxury preference (Jain and Rath 2023), debt-related distress may increase it (Wang et al. 2020b). Financial insecurity can reinforce frugality and weaken luxury preference (Hampson et al. 2021), yet luxury goods symbolize upward mobility and financial success (Liu et al. 2025b). Some consumers use luxury products to signal competence and secure economic rewards (Dubois et al. 2021), whereas luxury consumers still feel inauthentic and conflicted (Shukla et al. 2025). These conflicting patterns suggest that

financial status alone does not uniformly predict luxury preference.

Existing literature has explored financial constructs such as financial constraints, financial dissatisfaction, and financial deprivation, which compare financial resources with consumption capabilities to highlight external limitations or feelings of social inferiority (Dias et al. 2022; Sharma et al. 2014). Nonetheless, these approaches may overlook an important psychological dimension: consumers assess their financial status not only in terms of affordability but also in terms of financial aspirations and obligations. For instance, consumers may compare current finances to a past financial peak (Brown et al. 2009), a desire for upward mobility (McKenzie et al. 2022),

or recent savings behaviors (Sussman and O'Brien 2016). Others may evaluate their finances by whether they can fulfill familial and social obligations (Ward and Lynch 2019).

To capture these varied evaluations, this study introduces financial self-discrepancy, defined as the gap between one's actual financial status and internal standards, including financial aspirations (ideal self) or obligations (ought self) (Higgins 1987). We propose that these self-discrepancies help explain why some consumers prefer luxury products while others avoid them. As self-discrepancies disrupt psychological equilibrium, consumers may turn to luxury products as a compensatory response (Kim et al. 2025; Mandel et al. 2021). However, self-discrepancy remains underexplored in financial contexts (Rauber et al. 2024). Moreover, no prior research directly compares the effects of actual–ideal versus actual–ought discrepancies on luxury preference, as the latter is largely neglected in the literature (Hu et al. 2022).

Drawing upon regulatory focus theory (Higgins 1998), this study proposes that financial actual–ideal and actual–ought discrepancies activate distinct motivational orientations: promotion and prevention focus, respectively, which lead to different patterns of luxury preference. actual–ideal discrepancy, which reflects unmet financial aspirations (Higgins 1987), is expected to increase luxury preference as a compensatory form of symbolic self-completion. Conversely, actual–ought discrepancy, associated with perceived failure to meet financial obligations, is expected to evoke regulatory restraint and weaken luxury preference.

This study also examines well-being as a mediating mechanism. Although prior work links self-discrepancy to diminished hedonic well-being (Pupelis and Šeinauskienė 2023), this study finds that only eudaimonic well-being mediates the relationship between actual–ought discrepancy and luxury preference. Conversely, while actual–ideal discrepancies reduce hedonic well-being, they do not significantly affect luxury preference. This challenges the assumption that short-term affective discomfort is sufficient to drive compensatory consumption (Lee and Sadachar 2024; Pupelis and Šeinauskienė 2023; Syahrivar et al. 2022).

This study makes three key contributions to the literature. First, it advances understanding of finances in luxury preference by moving beyond external-constraint perspectives to a self-discrepancy framework. This reframing shows that consumers' financial self-evaluations, whether aspirational or obligation-based gaps, generate opposing motivational pathways for luxury preference. Second, it extends self-discrepancy and regulatory focus theories by showing that financial actual–ideal and actual–ought gaps activate distinct regulatory orientations, thereby identifying the conditions that shape luxury preference. Third, it integrates self-discrepancy theory and consumer well-being into a unified framework, offering a new lens to explain how unmet aspirations and obligations translate into luxury preference through well-being.

The remainder of this study is structured as follows. Section 2 presents the theoretical background and hypothesis development. Section 3 outlines the methodology and findings.

Section 4 provides the general discussion. Section 5 concludes with the theoretical contributions, managerial implications, limitations, and future research directions.

2 | Theoretical Background

2.1 | Regulatory Focus Theory

Regulatory focus theory (Higgins 1998) provides a motivational framework for understanding how individuals pursue goals and respond to self-discrepancies. It distinguishes between two orientations: promotion focus, which is linked to growth, aspirations, and accomplishments, and prevention focus, which emphasizes duties, obligations, and the avoidance of negative outcomes (Fatemi and Wan 2024). These orientations shape both emotional responses to self-discrepancies and compensatory consumption behaviors (Cao et al. 2025; Park and Ryu 2025). For instance, prevention-focused consumers manage purchases after buying to ensure responsible use, whereas promotion-focused consumers may lose interest post-purchase and quickly shift to new goals (Pandey and Tripathi 2022). A promotion focus encourages eager strategies to attain desired gains, while a prevention focus promotes vigilant strategies to avoid potential losses (Kim et al. 2024). These orientations also affect how consumers interpret product messages, manage discomfort, and cope with perceived failures (Krishna et al. 2023).

Although regulatory focus is not directly caused by self-discrepancies, it shapes how individuals evaluate and respond to them (Higgins 1998). A promotion focus aligns with the ideal self, reflecting personal aspirations (Kwon and Park 2023). Individuals with this orientation are sensitive to the presence or absence of positive outcomes (Fatemi and Wan 2024). Promotion-focused individuals pursue goals that signal advancement and self-affirmation (Kim et al. 2024). When they fail to meet their ideals, they experience dejection-related emotions such as disappointment or sadness (Higgins 1998). Exposure to ideal-related cues can heighten the pursuit of aspirational goals (Krishna et al. 2023). Promotion-focused individuals are also less risk-averse, more responsive to gain-framed messages (Park and Ryu 2025), and more attracted to products that symbolize future growth and optimism (Kim et al. 2024).

By contrast, a prevention focus corresponds to the ought self, reflecting social and familial obligations (Kwon and Park 2023). Individuals with this orientation are more attuned to the presence or absence of negative outcomes (Kim et al. 2024). They prioritize risk avoidance, stability, and rule compliance (Fatemi and Wan 2024). Failure to meet obligations evokes agitation-related emotions such as anxiety or guilt (Higgins 1998). This orientation encourages cautious decision-making, cost-efficient choices, and utilitarian product preference (Kim et al. 2024; Krishna et al. 2023; Pandey and Tripathi 2022).

Regulatory focus can be induced by situational cues (Higgins 1998). When aspirations become salient, individuals adopt a promotion focus, viewing the current state as a

non-gain or a missed opportunity to achieve a higher ideal (Fatemi and Wan 2024; Kwon and Park 2023). This perception often elicits negative emotions. In contrast, when obligations are emphasized, individuals adopt a prevention focus, interpreting the same status quo as a non-loss or a successful avoidance of harm (Fatemi and Wan 2024; Kwon and Park 2023). This perception results in positive emotions. The framing sensitivity highlights how temporary cues, such as financial aspirations and obligations, can activate regulatory orientations and influence compensatory consumption behaviors (Cao et al. 2025).

2.2 | Hypothesis Development

2.2.1 | Financial Self-Discrepancies and Luxury Preference

According to self-discrepancy theory (Higgins 1987), financial self-discrepancy arises when individuals compare their current financial status (the actual self) to internal standards (the ideal and ought self). A financial actual–ideal discrepancy reflects a gap with financial aspirations, whereas a financial actual–ought discrepancy reflects a gap with perceived obligations. These self-discrepancies elicit emotional discomfort, which drives consumers to engage in compensatory responses (Cao et al. 2025). Unlike related financial constructs such as financial constraints, financial dissatisfaction, or financial deprivation, financial self-discrepancy is identity-based and self-referential. Financial constraints refer to the perceived inability to engage in desired consumption (Tully et al. 2015). Financial dissatisfaction represents a subjective perception of having fewer financial resources than others (Briers and Laporte 2013). Financial deprivation captures perceived disadvantage relative to others (Sharma et al. 2014). By contrast, financial self-discrepancy captures internal conflicts between who individuals financially are and who they aspire to be or believe they should be.

Luxury products are high-end or exclusive items that convey status and social distinction (Wang 2022). They represent financial success and provide symbolic, hedonic, emotional, and social benefits that reinforce identity and social standing (Akarsu et al. 2025; Razmus et al. 2023). Their high price points often position consumers within aspirational social hierarchies (Wang 2022). Luxury products are valued for craftsmanship, cultural significance, sensory indulgence, and aesthetic appeal (Jebarajakirthy and Das 2021). Because luxury products represent financial achievement and discretionary spending (Dubois et al. 2021; Wang 2022), they offer a relevant domain for examining financial self-discrepancies. For those with actual–ideal discrepancies, luxury products can align with the ideal self, whereas for those with actual–ought discrepancies, they may conflict with the ought self.

While the relationship between financial constructs and luxury preference has been examined, findings remain inconsistent, as summarized in Table 1. Several studies show that financial stressors can heighten luxury preference. Consumers who perceive their financial resources as insufficient prefer luxury products to restore self-esteem and psychological equilibrium

(Liu et al. 2025b; Mark et al. 2016; Sarial-Abi et al. 2023; Sivanathan and Pettit 2010). Individuals experiencing debt stress or reliance on borrowing also increase their luxury preference to counter perceived status demotion (Fan 2000; Wang et al. 2020b). By contrast, other studies indicate that financial constructs can suppress preference for luxury products. Consumers facing financial constraints or economic scarcity show lower luxury preference as resource stress limits discretionary consumption (Dahan and Sayag 2024; Mennekes and Schramm-Klein 2025). Similarly, financial hardship and financial insecurity weaken luxury preference by reinforcing savings orientation and risk aversion (Gupta and Mukherjee 2023; Hampson et al. 2021).

Some studies reveal mixed effects of financial conditions on luxury preference. Under income inequality, US consumers increase luxury search, whereas European consumers decrease it (Rözer et al. 2022). When financial resources are equally distributed, consumers feel less need to close possession gaps, reducing luxury preference. At the same time, equality makes small differences in possessions more visible, which increases luxury preference (Ordabayeva and Chandon 2011). Collectively, these inconsistent findings suggest that financial status alone does not fully explain why some consumers prefer luxury while others avoid it under financial strain. To resolve this gap, this study applies self-discrepancy theory (Higgins 1987) to financial contexts to examine when financial conditions heighten luxury preference and when they suppress it.

Drawing on self-discrepancy theory (Higgins 1987), financial actual–ideal discrepancies refer to the gap between one's current finances and financial aspirations. Such aspirations may involve desired consumption (Dias et al. 2022), improving social standing (McKenzie et al. 2022), or regaining a previous financial peak (Brown et al. 2009). Financial actual–ideal discrepancies make unmet aspirations salient, which in turn triggers psychological discomfort and motivates consumers to engage in compensatory responses (Cao et al. 2025; Mandel et al. 2021).

Financial actual–ideal discrepancies heighten luxury preference by eliciting negative emotions and status restoration motives. These discrepancies elicit dejection-related emotions such as disappointment and dissatisfaction (Kim and Jang 2020). According to regulatory focus theory (Higgins 1998), these negative emotions increase the salience of the actual–ideal discrepancy, prompting consumers to adopt eager strategies to reduce it. Consumers then use products aligned with their ideals to restore emotional balance (Fatemi and Wan 2024). Relative deprivation further reinforces this process. When consumers perceive themselves as worse off than others, they experience anger and resentment, which intensify the urge to restore their status (Smith et al. 2011; Yang et al. 2025). This urge leads consumers to prefer costly products to signal reputation, such as expensive green products (Griskevicius et al. 2010). Luxury products fulfill this need because their expense and visibility make them effective markers of achievement and upward mobility (Shukla et al. 2025; Wang 2022). At the same time, luxury provides pleasure, excitement, and prestige (Akarsu et al. 2025; Gupta and Mukherjee 2023;

TABLE 1 | Related literature on financial constructs and luxury preference.

Publication	Objective	Context and sample size	Financial construct	Definition	Construct role	Findings	Effect on luxury preference
Liu et al. (2025b)	Investigates how perceived financial scarcity shapes luxury preference and whether perceived control mediates this relationship.	China (experiment, $N = 578$)	Perceived scarcity	An unpleasant state of having insufficient financial resources to meet consumers' needs.	Independent variable	Consumers experiencing perceived scarcity choose luxury products to restore psychological equilibrium.	Positive
Mennekes and Schramm-Klein (2025)	Examines how crisis-driven inflation and product scarcity affect consumer behavior.	Germany (survey, $N = 281$)	Financial constraints	Limited financial resources that force consumers to make trade-offs.	Independent variable	Consumers facing financial constraints experience heightened stress, reducing their luxury consumption.	Negative
Dahan and Sayag (2024)	Investigates whether economic scarcity shifts consumption from luxury to necessity products.	Israel (archival data, 2011–2018, $N = 21,800$)	Economic scarcity	Financial constraints from lack of salary or social support.	Independent variable	Consumers experiencing economic scarcity reduce luxury spending.	Negative
Sarial-Abi et al. (2023)	Examines how financial scarcity affects discretionary spending, borrowing, and investing.	- India (survey, $N = 1106$) - USA (experiment, $N = 621$) - Italy (archival data, 1995–2016, $N = 8000$) - Germany (archival data, 2001–2013, $N = 23,660$)	Financial scarcity	Perception of limited financial resources insufficient to cover necessities or desired wants.	Independent variable	Consumers experiencing financial scarcity increase discretionary spending, including luxury preference.	Positive
Gupta and Mukherjee (2023)	Investigates how pandemic experiences shape saving attitudes and hedonic preferences.	India (in-depth interviews, $N = 35$)	Financial hardship	Perception of insufficient financial resources to sustain usual living standards.	Moderator	Consumers facing financial hardship show decreased luxury preference due to stronger savings orientation.	Negative
Rözer et al. (2022)	Investigates how income inequality affects materialistic values and luxury preferences.	- Europe (archival data, 2004–2016, $N = 450$ country-years in Study 2) - USA (archival data, 2006–2016, $N = 561$ state-years observations in Study 2)	Income inequality	Objective measurement of household disposable income disparities.	Independent variable	US consumers increase luxury search under income inequality, whereas European consumers decrease it.	Mixed
Hampson et al. (2021)	Examines the relationship between consumer confidence and conspicuous luxury consumption.	Brazil (survey, $N = 1043$)	Financial insecurity	Perception of insufficient financial resources to cover needs, goals, and unforeseen expenses.	Mediator	Consumers with lower confidence experience greater financial insecurity, which in turn reduces luxury consumption.	Negative
Wang et al. (2020b)	Investigates how debt stress influences luxury consumption, with perceived status demotion as a mediator and lay rationalism as a moderator.	- China (survey and experiment, $N = 692$) - USA (experiment, $N = 164$)	Debt stress	Negative emotions from financial obligations that exceed one's coping capacity.	Independent variable	Consumers under debt stress perceive status demotion, which increases their luxury preference.	Positive

(Continues)

TABLE 1 | (Continued)

Publication	Objective	Context and sample size	Financial construct	Definition	Construct role	Findings	Effect on luxury preference
Bricker et al. (2020)	Examines the role of status in household consumption and financial decisions.	USA (survey and archival data, $N = \text{not specified}$)	Relative income	Relative standing of a household's income compared to others in the same census tract.	Independent variable	Consumers with lower income rank show lower luxury consumption.	Positive
Mark et al. (2016)	Investigates how demand for premium brands grows during economic recessions.	- USA (archival data, $N = \text{not specified}$) - USA (survey, $N = 1100$)	Budgetary constraints	Financial limitations that restrict consumers from purchasing high-cost items.	Independent variable	During economic recessions, consumers engage in cross-category indulgence, which in turn increases luxury consumption.	Positive
Griskevicius et al. (2013)	Examines how resource scarcity influences consumer behavior, with early-life socioeconomic status as a moderator.	USA (experiment, $N = 61$ in Study 2)	Resource scarcity	Economic downturn cues that activate perceptions of limited financial resources.	Independent variable	Consumers with low early-life socioeconomic status increase luxury preference under resource scarcity, whereas those with high early-life socioeconomic status reduce it.	Mixed
Ordabayeva and Chandon (2011)	Examines how economic inequality influences conspicuous and inconspicuous consumption among consumers at the bottom of the distribution.	Netherlands (experiment, $N = 579$)	Economic Equality	Perception of how evenly financial resources are distributed among others.	Independent variable	Greater equality reduces the possession gap, which in turn lowers luxury consumption. At the same time, greater equality amplifies position gains, which in turn increases luxury consumption.	Mixed
Sivanathan and Pettit (2010)	Investigates whether conspicuous consumption is a psychological response to threats to self-integrity.	USA (experiment, $N = 95$ in Study 3)	Financial strain (low income)	Limited financial resources associated with diminished self-integrity.	Independent variable	Consumers with financial strain experience lower self-esteem, which in turn increases their luxury preference.	Positive
Fan (2000)	Investigates expenditure pattern differences between borrowing and non-borrowing households.	USA (archival data, $N = 5174$)	Borrowing status	Households that rely on borrowing, indicating financial strain and debt obligations.	Independent variable	Borrowers allocate more spending to luxury goods with social display value.	Positive
This study	Investigates how financial self-discrepancies influence luxury preferences.	Australia (experiment, $N = 1132$)	Financial actual-ideal and actual-ought discrepancies	A financial actual-ideal discrepancy reflects a gap with financial aspirations, whereas a financial actual-ought discrepancy reflects a gap with perceived obligations.	Independent variables	Consumers facing financial actual-ideal discrepancies show higher luxury preference, whereas those experiencing financial actual-ought discrepancies show lower luxury preference.	Mixed

Wang 2022), helping financially ideal-discrepant consumers to restore perceived status and emotional equilibrium.

Regulatory focus theory (Higgins 1998) suggests that financial actual–ideal discrepancies activate a promotion-focused orientation, directing consumers toward aspirations and accomplishments. Because luxury products symbolize achievement and future potential (Akarsu et al. 2025), consumers may view them as symbolic means of coping with these discrepancies. Financial actual–ideal discrepancies can also provoke perceived constraints (Wang et al. 2020b), which motivate consumers to seek rare products to reassert control (Hamilton et al. 2019). Since luxury products are perceived as exclusive (Razmus et al. 2023), they align with this compensatory motive. Promotion-focused individuals also value the social-adjustive function of luxury, which strengthens their preferences (Wang et al. 2020a). This tendency persists even when luxury products involve financial and psychological risks (Luo and Park 2024).

Compensatory consumption theory (Mandel et al. 2021; Rucker and Galinsky 2008) argues that when consumers experience self-discrepancies, they adopt symbolic self-completion strategies to restore their self-worth. Luxury products serve this role because they enhance perceived competence (Dubois et al. 2021) and signal sophistication (Wang 2022), which in turn reinforce self-worth (Liu et al. 2025b). As actual–ideal discrepancies undermine self-worth, consumers may turn to luxury products as symbolic resources to compensate for these deficits (Cao et al. 2025). Psychological ownership further supports this reasoning. When consumers experience actual–ideal discrepancies, feelings of “mine-ness” toward possessions help to restore self-worth (Kim et al. 2025; Pierce et al. 2003). Luxury products provide a form of symbolic ownership (Kim et al. 2025), allowing financially ideal-discrepant consumers to compensate for diminished self-worth.

Taken together, this study proposes that consumers experiencing financial actual–ideal discrepancies show stronger luxury preference. Past research shows that actual–ideal discrepancies increase preference for products aligned with the ideal self, such as those signaling competence, ethnicity, or ability (Liu et al. 2025a; Wang et al. 2023). Thus, similar patterns are expected in financial contexts.

Hypothesis 1 (H1). *Financial actual–ideal discrepancy increases consumers’ preference for luxury products over non-luxury alternatives.*

Financial actual–ought discrepancies refer to the gap between one’s current finances and perceived obligations (Higgins 1987). These obligations may include prudent money management (Garbinsky et al. 2021), saving for emergencies (Sussman and O’Brien 2016), or fulfilling familial and societal responsibilities (Ward and Lynch 2019). Similar to actual–ideal gaps, financial actual–ought discrepancies make unfulfilled obligations salient, which evokes distress and encourages consumers to avoid indulgent or risky financial behaviors (Cao et al. 2025).

This study posits that consumers experiencing financial actual–ought discrepancies exhibit lower luxury preference. Drawing on regulatory focus theory (Higgins 1998), these discrepancies

activate a prevention-focused orientation that prioritizes risk aversion, resource conservation, and a desire for stability (Luo and Park 2024; Park and Ryu 2025). In this orientation, avoiding luxury products serves as a way to fulfill obligations, allowing consumers to frame luxury avoidance as a non-loss. For example, under financial obligations, consumers reduce luxury preference and shift toward savings behaviors (Gupta and Mukherjee 2023). Luxury preference conflicts with financial obligations as these products are perceived as expensive and wasteful (Dubois et al. 2021). Prevention-focused consumers also prioritize functional attributes (Krishna et al. 2023) and emphasize cost–benefit evaluations (Pandey and Tripathi 2022), making them less likely to prefer luxury products.

Luxury products conflict with societal obligations tied to the ought self. They are often framed as “sinful consumption” that undermines norms of prudence and responsibility (Mo et al. 2022). Luxury products can undermine authenticity, as luxury consumers are judged by family and peers as showy, self-centered, or narcissistic (Dubois et al. 2021; Razmus et al. 2023). Moreover, conspicuous luxury use can raise the ought self-threshold, as others expect greater financial obligations from luxury consumers (Sundie et al. 2020). For consumers experiencing financial actual–ought discrepancies, such social threats make luxury preference especially risky. Consequently, they are more likely to avoid luxury products in favor of safer, obligation-consistent options.

Financial actual–ought discrepancies create temporary self-threats by highlighting failures to meet financial obligations (Cao et al. 2025). Compensatory consumption theory posits that when consumers experience self-threats, they may cope by dissociating from threatening cues (Ranjitha et al. 2023). For instance, students whose universities are threatened are less likely to prefer university-related products (Mandel et al. 2021). Because luxury users are often stereotyped as irresponsible and lacking self-control (Razmus et al. 2023), associating with luxury products can amplify feelings of failing financial obligations. To avoid this identity threat, consumers experiencing financial actual–ought discrepancies may dissociate from luxury products, reducing their luxury preference.

Hypothesis 2 (H2). *Financial actual–ought discrepancy decreases consumers’ preference for luxury products compared to non-luxury alternatives.*

2.2.2 | The Role of Hedonic Well-Being

Hedonic well-being refers to the subjective experience of positive emotions and overall enjoyment of life (Ryff et al. 2021). It comprises three dimensions: life satisfaction, positive affect, and negative affect. Life satisfaction reflects the extent to which personal aspirations are fulfilled. Positive affect includes emotions such as joy and enthusiasm, while negative affect encompasses aversive states like sadness or hopelessness. High hedonic well-being arises when positive affect and life satisfaction outweigh negative affect, producing emotional balance (Qayyum et al. 2023). In consumer research, hedonic well-being is sensitive to self-discrepancy and functions as a mechanism

that shapes consumption behaviors (Pupelis and Šeinauskienė 2023; Qayyum et al. 2023).

Given a strong correlation between financial and overall well-being (Garg et al. 2024), financial actual–ideal discrepancies may reduce hedonic well-being by disrupting the balance between positive and negative emotions. actual–ideal discrepancies diminish positive self-evaluations and foster feelings of inadequacy, lowering consumers' pride (Kwon and Park 2023). These discrepancies also reduce happiness by weakening life satisfaction (Lee and Sadachar 2024; Pupelis and Šeinauskienė 2023). Dejection-related emotions such as disappointment and sadness further diminish hedonic well-being (Cao et al. 2025; Higgins 1987; Ryff et al. 2021). In financial contexts, unmet ideal goals generate psychological distress that lowers hedonic well-being (Garg et al. 2024). These emotional deficits also weaken pleasure and life satisfaction, further reducing hedonic well-being (Gedecho et al. 2023). Past research shows that actual–ideal discrepancies in social status and gender similarly impair life satisfaction (Kim and Jang 2020; Ranjitha et al. 2023). Drawing on regulatory focus theory (Higgins 1998), promotion-focused individuals confronted with unfulfilled ideals interpret them as lost opportunities, which reduces enjoyment of the present. Collectively, these findings suggest that financial actual–ideal discrepancies may erode hedonic well-being by undermining emotional balance and life satisfaction.

Hedonic well-being may mediate the effect of financial actual–ideal discrepancy on luxury preference. When hedonic well-being is diminished, financial ideal-discrepant consumers look for products that provide emotional relief (Pupelis and Šeinauskienė 2023). Luxury products become appealing because they provide immediate gratification and positive emotions (Akarsu et al. 2025; Wang et al. 2020b). These consumers also prefer luxury products to compensate for emotional deficits and alleviate stress (Wang et al. 2024). Declines in life satisfaction further intensify the appeal of luxury products. As luxury products are associated with financial success and aspirational progress (Razmus et al. 2023), consumers experiencing financial actual–ideal discrepancies may prefer luxury products as a way to restore overall life satisfaction. Based on these foregoing discussions, the following hypothesis is formulated:

Hypothesis 3 (H3). *Hedonic well-being mediates the positive relationship between financial actual–ideal discrepancy and preference for luxury products.*

2.2.3 | The Role of Eudaimonic Well-Being

Eudaimonic well-being reflects the pursuit of meaning, purpose, and personal growth (Ryff et al. 2021). It encompasses three primary dimensions: autonomy, competence, and relatedness (Weinstein and Stone 2018). Autonomy involves choice and self-direction, competence reflects mastery and accomplishment, and relatedness refers to meaningful social connections (Ryff et al. 2021). High eudaimonic well-being occurs when individuals feel autonomous, competent, and socially connected, reflecting sustained psychological functioning and

fulfillment (Williams et al. 2022). In consumer research, eudaimonic well-being guides consumers towards co-creation tourism, inclusive branding, or altruistic choices (Piracci et al. 2024; Qayyum et al. 2023). Given the social salience of financial obligations, this study proposes that financial actual–ought discrepancies reduce eudaimonic well-being.

Firstly, financial actual–ought discrepancies undermine consumers' competence. When consumers perceive failure to meet financial obligations, they feel inadequate and less capable (Weinstein and Stone 2018). actual–ought discrepancies can also signal failure in maintaining life quality, reinforcing feelings of inadequacy and inability to fulfill obligations (Busseri and Merrick 2016; Liu et al. 2025a). Financially ought-discrepant consumers are sensitive to the presence of negative outcomes (Fatemi and Wan 2024), making unmet obligations more salient and further lowering perceived competence (Weinstein and Stone 2018).

Secondly, financial actual–ought discrepancies impair perceived relatedness. As the ought self is also defined by social and familial obligations, failing to meet these obligations threatens social belonging and acceptance (Higgins 1987; Lee and Sadachar 2024). These discrepancies can trigger guilt, which often drives social withdrawal and weakens interpersonal relationships (Ranjitha et al. 2023). Prior studies indicate that unmet obligations, such as unpaid debts, strain social relationships (Giuffrè 2023). Moreover, eudaimonic relatedness involves feeling accepted as one's authentic self (Ryff et al. 2021). Financial actual–ought discrepancies emphasize the misalignment between the actual and ought self (Higgins 1987), fostering inauthenticity and reducing perceived relatedness. Conversely, eudaimonic autonomy may remain relatively unaffected. Although financial actual–ought discrepancies impose social obligations, individuals may still perceive their coping responses as self-endorsed, thereby preserving autonomy.

Eudaimonic well-being may mediate the impact of financial actual–ought discrepancies on luxury preference. When eudaimonic well-being is diminished, consumers experiencing these discrepancies seek to protect their sense of competence and relatedness. In such cases, luxury products are viewed as indulgent and financially imprudent (Shukla et al. 2025). Avoiding them allows consumers to illustrate financial responsibility and signal financial prudence (Wang et al. 2025). Social norms often frame luxury as excessive and unnecessary (Dubois et al. 2021; Wang 2022). In line with these norms, consumers may avoid luxury to maintain social approval and belonging. Consumers with financial actual–ought discrepancies also adopt vigilant strategies that prioritize obligations and minimize risk (Higgins 1998). For these consumers, not choosing luxury products is seen as a non-loss that prevents further threats to already weakened eudaimonic well-being. Thus, reduced eudaimonic well-being serves as the psychological mechanism through which financial actual–ought discrepancies decrease luxury preference.

Hypothesis 4 (H4). *Eudaimonic well-being mediates the negative relationship between financial actual–ought discrepancy and preference for luxury products.*

2.2.4 | The Role of Access-Based Luxury Formats

The rise of the sharing economy and democratized luxury introduces new luxury formats that emphasize partial or temporary ownership, moving beyond traditional classifications (Wang 2022). These access-based luxury formats include renting, second-hand, and co-ownership luxury (Christodoulides et al. 2021). Unlike conventional luxury ownership which involves high financial costs (Jebarajakirthy and Das 2021), access-based luxury formats provide comparable benefits at lower financial expense (Christodoulides et al. 2021). Because these formats differ in symbolic and financial trade-offs, they may moderate the relationship between financial actual-ideal discrepancy and luxury preference.

Renting luxury, or liquid luxury, refers to the acquisition of luxury products for a finite period (Wang 2022). This format is available through subscription-based or peer-to-peer platforms (Christodoulides et al. 2021). For example, MyWardrobeHQ and Vivrelle provide access to luxury fashion through rental and subscription options. Renting enables symbolic possession and hedonic pleasure without long-term financial commitment (Pantano and Stylos 2020). Because it involves lower financial cost, renting reduces guilt, which is often associated with conventional luxury format (Hampson et al. 2021). Since renting only offers temporary use, it may help financially ideal-discrepant consumers avoid post-purchase aversive emotions such as self-blame or regret (Dias et al. 2022). Renting also aligns with frugality norms, allowing consumers to pursue ideal goals without overspending (Lang and Zhang 2024). For consumers experiencing financial actual-ideal discrepancies, these features make renting luxury attractive because it allows them to approach their ideal self symbolically without worsening their current finances.

Second-hand luxury reflects the purchase of pre-owned luxury products through resale platforms, such as Vestiaire or Luxury Garage Sale (Christodoulides et al. 2021). This format offers permanent ownership at lower financial cost, making luxury products more accessible to consumers with limited resources (Wang et al. 2020b). Unlike renting luxury, second-hand luxury carries perceived risks such as social stigma, quality concerns, unreliable sellers, and associations with counterfeiting (Jain and Rathi 2023; Luo and Park 2024). Nonetheless, these risks may be acceptable trade-offs for consumers experiencing financial actual-ideal discrepancies. Regulatory focus theory indicates that promotion-focused consumers concentrate on aspirational goals and downplay potential risks (Park and Ryu 2025). Promotion-focused orientation reduces concerns about functional, financial, and seller-related risks in second-hand luxury (Luo and Park 2024). Therefore, when consumers adopt a promotion focus to cope with financial actual-ideal discrepancies, second-hand luxury offers a viable compromise, providing symbolic self-completion while reducing financial burden.

Co-ownership luxury involves shared ownership of luxury products among multiple consumers (Christodoulides et al. 2021). For instance, Pacaso sells vacation homes in fractional shares, giving each co-owner usage rights. While this format lowers individual financial costs, it dilutes uniqueness and personal control (Christodoulides et al. 2021).

As uniqueness is central to luxury products (Jebarajakirthy and Das 2021), co-ownership may be less attractive to consumers experiencing financial actual-ideal discrepancies. It can highlight the inability to afford independent ownership, intensifying the salience of insufficient current finances. Drawing on compensatory consumption theory, consumers tend to avoid products that pose further psychological risks or symbolic ambiguity (Mandel et al. 2021). Hence, co-ownership formats are unlikely to increase luxury preference under conditions of financial actual-ideal discrepancy.

Renting and second-hand luxury formats provide financially actual-ideal discrepant consumers with symbolic access to luxury while minimizing strain on current finances. These formats enable aspirational expression and compensatory consumption without undermining the financial actual self. By contrast, co-ownership undermines exclusivity and control, which weakens luxury's symbolic value and may intensify awareness of insufficient current finances. Taken together, these differences suggest that the effect of financial actual-ideal discrepancy on luxury preference depends on the access-based luxury format. As prior research shows that the effects of self-discrepancies on product preference are moderated by product categories (Cao et al. 2025), financial actual-ideal discrepancies may increase preference for luxury in renting and second-hand formats but not in co-ownership.

Hypothesis 5 (H5). *The effect of financial actual-ideal discrepancy on luxury preference is moderated by access-based luxury formats.*

3 | Method

To test the proposed hypotheses, six experiments and two cross-sectional studies were conducted. Studies 1A and 2A experimentally manipulated financial actual-ideal and actual-ought discrepancies to test their causal effects on luxury preference using a willingness-to-pay scale (H1, H2). Studies 1B and 2B replicated these effects using cross-sectional designs with inconspicuous stimuli to rule out the possibility that product preference was driven by visual design. Studies 1C and 2C further strengthened H1 and H2 using alternative manipulations and binary choice measures. Study 3 tested hedonic and eudaimonic well-being as mediators (H3, H4), while Study 4 examined the moderating role of access-based luxury formats on the actual-ideal discrepancy effect (H5). Due to space constraints, detailed descriptions of Studies 1B, 1C, 2B, and 2C are provided in Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix A.

Participants were recruited on Prolific (www.prolific.com), a reliable platform for academic research, and compensated for their participation (Kwon and Park 2023). Demographic information for each study is presented in Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix B. Eligibility criteria included being 18 years or older, residing in Australia, being fluent in English and holding a minimum approval rate of 95%. Sample sizes were determined using G*Power, as shown in Table 2. All studies employed random sampling, using summary questions, attention checks, and completion time restrictions to ensure data quality.

TABLE 2 | Summary of the eight studies.

Study	Hypothesis tested	Design	Sample size (<i>N</i>)	Sample size justification	Independent variable(s)	Dependent variable(s)
1A	H1	2 × 2 between-subjects design	128	$f = 0.25$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.80	• actual–ideal discrepancy (high vs. low)	• Willingness to pay (watches: luxury vs. non-luxury)
1B	H1	Cross-sectional study	60	$f^2 = 0.15$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.80, plus 10% potential outliers	• actual–ideal discrepancy (measured)	• Product preference (inconspicuous backpacks: luxury vs. non-luxury, measured)
1C	H1	One factor between-subjects	88	$w = 0.3$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.80	• actual–ideal discrepancy (high vs. low)	• Product preference (sunglasses: luxury vs. non-luxury, binary)
2A	H2	2 × 2 between-subjects design	128	$f = 0.25$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.80	• actual–ought discrepancy (high vs. low)	• Willingness to pay (watches: luxury vs. non-luxury)
2B	H2	Cross-sectional study	60	$f^2 = 0.15$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.80, plus 10% potential outliers	• actual–ought discrepancy (measured)	• Product preference (inconspicuous backpacks: luxury vs. non-luxury, measured)
2C	H2	One factor between-subjects	88	$w = 0.3$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.80	• actual–ought discrepancy (high vs. low)	• Product preference (sunglasses: luxury vs. non-luxury, binary)
3	H3 and H4	One-factor between-subjects	300	$f^2 = 0.10$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.80, plus 10% potential outliers	• IV: actual–ideal discrepancy, actual–ought discrepancy (measured) • Mediator: Hedonic well-being, Eudaimonic well-being (measured)	• Product preference (footwear: luxury vs. non-luxury, measured)
4	H5	2 × 3 between-subjects design	280	$f = 0.25$, $\alpha = 0.05$, power = 0.95, plus 10% potential outliers	• actual–ideal discrepancy (high vs. low) • Moderator: consumption form (renting vs. second-hand vs. co-owned)	• Willingness to pay (luxury, measured)

The focus on Australian participants aimed to diversify a literature heavily skewed toward USA (46.6%) and Asian (25%) samples (Rauber et al. 2024). While Australians share an individualistic orientation with North Americans, they exhibit lower power distance and greater egalitarianism (Saunders and Wong 2013), which may shape distinct perceptions of financial aspirations and obligations. To minimize common method bias, all studies incorporated procedural precautions: anonymizing participant data, conducting preliminary reliability checks of all scales, and using concise, clearly worded items to ensure comprehension (Jebarajakirthy and Das 2021).

3.1 | Study 1A

Studies 1A–1C tested the effect of financial actual–ideal discrepancies on luxury preferences (H1) using varied manipulations, product types, and preference measures. Full details of Studies 1B and 1C are reported in Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix A.

3.1.1 | Sample and Data Collection

Study 1A employed a 2 (actual–ideal discrepancy: high vs. low) $\times$ 2 (product type: luxury vs. non-luxury) between-subjects design. After excluding 12 nonsensical responses from 140 completions, the final sample comprised 128 Australian participants ($M_{\text{age}} = 35.4$, 58% female; see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix B). To manipulate financial actual–ideal discrepancy, participants completed a writing task adapted from Rucker and Galinsky (2008). In the high-discrepancy condition, they described a financial aspiration they had not yet achieved and reflected on how their current financial situation fell short of it. In the low-discrepancy condition, they described a financial aspiration they had already achieved and reflected on how their current situation allowed them to fulfill it. This procedure captures subjective perceptions of inadequacy rather than objective financial constraints, in line with self-discrepancy theory (Higgins 1987). A two-item actual–ideal discrepancy scale (Huber et al. 2018) served as the manipulation check (see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix C for full scales). Participants were then shown either a Gucci (luxury) or Casio (non-luxury) watch and rated their preference on the willingness-to-pay scale (1 = definitely no, 7 = definitely yes). To verify stimulus validity, they completed a perceived luxury check using a single-item measure (Shin et al. 2023).

3.1.2 | Results

Preliminary analyses: The self-discrepancy scale showed acceptable reliability in both conditions ($r = 0.72$).

Manipulation checks: A one-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) confirmed successful discrepancy manipulation, $F(1, 126) = 8.07$, $p = 0.005$, $\eta^2 = 0.06$. High-discrepancy participants scored higher ($M = 4.96$, $SD = 1.49$) than low-discrepancy participants ($M = 4.16$, $SD = 1.67$).

Perceived luxury checks: One-sample t -tests confirmed perceived luxury. The Gucci watch was rated above the midpoint ($M = 5.2$,

$SD = 1.38$), $t(63) = 6.96$, $p < 0.001$, while the Casio watch below the midpoint ($M = 3.47$, $SD = 1.55$), $t(63) = -2.74$, $p = 0.008$.

Main results: A 2×2 ANOVA showed a significant interaction between actual–ideal discrepancy and product type on willingness to pay, $F(1, 124) = 13.03$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.10$. The main effect of product type was significant $F(1, 124) = 9.37$, $p = 0.003$, $\eta^2 = 0.07$, whereas the main effect of discrepancy was not, $F(1, 124) = 0.25$, $p = 0.616$, $\eta^2 = 0.002$. Participants in the high-discrepancy/luxury condition reported the highest preference ($M = 4.41$), compared to the other three conditions ($M_{\text{high-discrepancy/non-luxury}} = 2.12$, $M_{\text{low-discrepancy/luxury}} = 3.00$, and $M_{\text{low-discrepancy/non-luxury}} = 3.19$), supporting H1.

3.2 | Study 2A

Studies 2A–2C examined the relationship between financial actual–ought discrepancy and luxury preference (H2). Full details of Studies 2B and 2C are provided in Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix A.

3.2.1 | Sample and Data Collection

Study 2A used a 2 (actual–ought discrepancy: high vs. low) $\times$ 2 (product type: luxury vs. non-luxury) between-subjects design. After excluding nine nonsensical responses from 137 completions, the final sample comprised 128 Australian participants ($M_{\text{age}} = 36.1$, 48% female, see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix B). Similar to Study 1A, participants completed a writing task adapted from Rucker and Galinsky (2008). Participants were randomly assigned to conditions using the University of Southern Queensland survey platform's randomization function. In the high-discrepancy condition, they described a financial obligation they felt responsible for but were unable to fulfill and reflected on how their current financial situation made it difficult to meet this obligation. In the low-discrepancy condition, they described a financial obligation they had successfully fulfilled and reflected on how their current situation enabled them to do so. This approach emphasizes participants' subjective perceptions of meeting or failing obligations, consistent with self-discrepancy theory (Higgins 1987). The manipulation check consisted of a two-item scale (Huber et al. 2018); see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix C for full scales); including items such as “My current financial situation is far from where it should be.” In the product preference task, consistent with Study 1A, participants evaluated either a Gucci (luxury) or Casio (non-luxury) watch by rating their willingness to pay and perceived luxury (Shin et al. 2023).

3.2.2 | Results

Preliminary analyses: The actual–ought discrepancy scale demonstrated acceptable reliability in both groups ($r = 0.74$ and $r = 0.75$).

Manipulation checks: A one-way ANOVA confirmed effective discrepancy manipulation, $F(1, 126) = 8.45$, $p = 0.004$, $\eta^2 = 0.06$,

with higher scores in the high-discrepancy group ($M = 4.96$, $SD = 1.58$) than the low-discrepancy group ($M = 4.14$, $SD = 1.59$).

Perceived luxury checks: One-sample t -tests confirmed that Gucci was perceived as luxurious ($M = 4.58$, $SD = 1.65$), $t(63) = 2.80$, $p = 0.006$, and Casio was non-luxurious ($M = 3.59$, $SD = 1.61$), $t(63) = -2.02$, $p = 0.04$.

Main results: A 2×2 ANOVA revealed a significant interaction between discrepancy and product type on willingness to pay, $F(1, 124) = 12.40$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.09$. Both main effects were significant: discrepancy, $F(1, 124) = 6.73$, $p = 0.011$, $\eta^2 = 0.05$; and product type, $F(1, 124) = 4.16$, $p = 0.044$, $\eta^2 = 0.03$. Willingness to pay was highest in the high-discrepancy/non-luxury condition ($M = 4.62$), compared to the other three conditions ($M_{\text{high-discrepancy/luxury}} = 2.75$, $M_{\text{low-discrepancy/luxury}} = 3.06$, and $M_{\text{low-discrepancy/non-luxury}} = 2.56$), supporting H2.

3.3 | Study 3

Study 3 tested whether consumer well-being mediated the effects of financial self-discrepancies on luxury preference, focusing on hedonic (H3) and eudaimonic (H4) well-being.

3.3.1 | Sample and Data Collection

Study 3 employed a two-condition, between-subjects experimental design. After excluding eight participants who failed attention checks from 308 completions, the final sample comprised 300 Australian participants ($M_{\text{age}} = 31.4$, 54% female; see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix B). Participants were randomly assigned to either a financial actual-ideal or actual-ought discrepancy condition. In the actual-ideal condition, they recalled financial aspirations they had not yet achieved, whereas in the actual-ought condition they recalled financial obligations they felt responsible for but had not yet fulfilled. To facilitate recall, participants selected five of 15 common financial goals or obligations that best matched their own experience. Consistent with Studies 1A and 2A, this procedure captures subjective perceptions of unmet aspirations or obligations. Participants then completed the same two-item discrepancy scales used in Studies 1A and 2A, followed by two well-being measures assessing hedonic (nine items) and eudaimonic (nine items) dimensions, adapted from Wilson et al. (2013) (see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix C for full scales). Finally, participants indicated their preference between Louis Vuitton (luxury) and Autry (non-luxury) sneakers,

labeled as options A and B, on a 7-point scale (1 = absolutely prefer option A; 7 = absolutely prefer option B).

3.3.2 | Results

Preliminary analyses: Discrepancy scales showed good reliability ($r_{\text{ideal}} = 0.75$, $r_{\text{ought}} = 0.74$). The well-being scales showed high internal consistency ($\alpha_{\text{hedonic}} = 0.91$, $\alpha_{\text{eudaimonic}} = 0.81$). No multicollinearity was detected (variance inflation factors = 1.05–2.32; all intercorrelations < 0.90). The regression equation specification error test confirmed model specification, $F(2, 144) = 1.50$, $p = 0.23$. Five multivariate outliers were excluded from the actual-ideal group using Mahalanobis distance, Leverage, and Cook's distance.

Main results of actual-ideal condition ($n = 145$): Financial actual-ideal discrepancy predicted lower hedonic well-being, $B = -0.46$, $t(143) = -7.21$, $p < 0.001$, 95% CI $[-0.58, -0.33]$. Nevertheless, mediation analysis (5000 bootstraps) showed no significant indirect effect on luxury preference via hedonic well-being, Average causal mediation effect (ACME) = 0.07, $p = 0.26$, 95% CI $[-0.05, 0.20]$ or eudaimonic well-being, ACME = -0.02 , $p = 0.78$, 95% CI $[-0.16, 0.12]$. Thus, H3 was not supported.

Main results of actual-ought condition ($n = 150$): Financial actual-ought discrepancy predicted lower eudaimonic well-being, $B = -0.21$, $t(148) = -5.19$, $p < 0.001$, 95% CI $[-0.30, -0.13]$. Mediation analysis (5000 bootstraps) indicated a significant indirect effect on luxury preference via eudaimonic well-being, ACME = -0.08 , $p < 0.001$, 95% CI $[-0.14, -0.05]$, accounting for 22% of the total effect ($B = -0.39$, $p < 0.001$), supporting H4 with the path coefficients displayed in Figure 1. No indirect effect was found via hedonic well-being, ACME = -0.003 , $p = 0.44$, 95% CI $[-0.01, 0.001]$. Sensitivity analysis showed the mediation remained robust unless $\rho > 0.5$ ($R^2 = 0.25$). Model fit indices (comparative fit index = 1.000, root mean square error of approximation = 0.000, standardized root mean square residual = 0.000) were trivially perfect due to a just-identified model ($df = 0$).

3.4 | Study 4

Study 4 tested Hypothesis 5, which posits that the effect of financial actual-ideal discrepancy on luxury preference is moderated by access-based luxury formats. It is expected that consumers with high financial actual-ideal discrepancies show greater luxury preference through their willingness to pay when luxury products are accessed through renting or second-hand formats, but not through co-ownership.

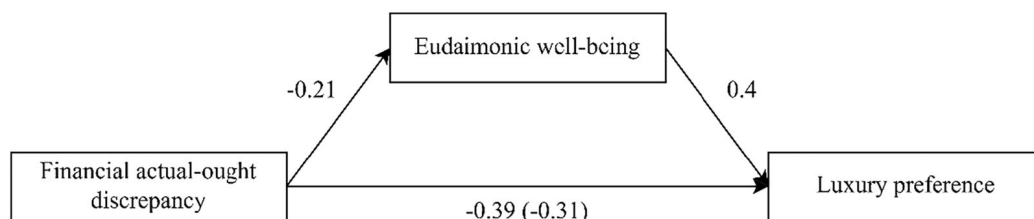


FIGURE 1 | Coefficients in the mediation model in Study 3.

Study 4 employed a 2 (actual–ideal discrepancy: high vs. low) $\times$ 3 (luxury format: renting vs. second-hand vs. co-ownership) between-subjects design. After excluding 12 meaningless responses from 292 completions, the final sample comprised 280 Australian participants ($M_{\text{age}} = 35.5$, 53% female; see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix B). Participants completed the same financial self-discrepancy manipulation and manipulation check used in Study 1A to capture subjective perceptions of unmet aspirations. They were then introduced to a fictitious luxury retailer, Nivora, which offered the same Burberry backpack across three consumption formats. In the renting condition, the backpack could be accessed temporarily for a fraction of the retail price without ownership. In the second-hand condition, it was described as a pre-owned, authenticated item available at a discount with full ownership. In the co-ownership condition, participants read about jointly sharing the product, cost, and usage with another person. To assess the validity of the format manipulation, participants rated two items on perceived ownership and exclusivity (e.g., “I would be the only person using this product”; 1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree) (see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix C for full scales). For the luxury preference task, participants reported their willingness to pay for the product.

3.4.2 | Results

Preliminary analyses: The discrepancy scale showed good reliability ($r = 0.72$ and $r = 0.71$).

Manipulation checks: A one-way ANOVA confirmed successful discrepancy manipulation, $F(1, 278) = 21.58$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.07$, with higher scores in the high-discrepancy group ($M = 4.97$, $SD = 1.54$) than the low-discrepancy group ($M = 4.08$, $SD = 1.68$). Perceived ownership differed by format, $F(2, 277) = 52.07$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.27$, second-hand ($M = 5.69$, $SD = 1.39$) $>$ co-ownership ($M = 4.22$, $SD = 1.79$) $>$ renting ($M = 3.29$, $SD = 1.64$). Perceived exclusivity also varied by format, $F(2, 277) = 36.24$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.21$, second-hand ($M = 5.39$, $SD = 1.67$) $>$ renting ($M = 4.41$, $SD = 1.95$) $>$ co-ownership ($M = 3.16$, $SD = 1.73$). A one-sample t -test confirmed the backpack was perceived as luxurious ($M = 5.19$, $SD = 1.32$), $t(279) = 15.06$, $p < 0.001$.

Main results: A 2×3 ANOVA showed a significant interaction between financial discrepancy and access-based luxury formats on willingness to pay, $F(2, 274) = 16.20$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.11$. In the high-discrepancy group, preference was highest for renting ($M = 5.70$, $SD = 1.39$), then second-hand ($M = 4.53$, $SD = 1.36$), and lowest for co-ownership ($M = 1.80$, $SD = 0.73$). In the low-discrepancy group, preferences were more uniform ($3.30 < M_s < 4.60$). A planned contrast in the high-discrepancy group confirmed stronger preference for renting/second-hand over co-ownership, $t(136) = 15.14$, $p < 0.001$. Tukey's tests showed all pairwise differences were significant ($ps < 0.001$) within the high-discrepancy group but not the low-discrepancy group, supporting H5.

This study examined how financial self-discrepancies shape luxury preference across eight studies, including four main experiments and four supplemental studies (see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix A). Studies 1A, 1B, and 1C consistently showed that when consumers reflected on discrepancies between their current finances and financial aspirations, their luxury preference increased. This effect held across both conspicuous and inconspicuous luxury products and remained robust across preference ratings, binary choices, and willingness-to-pay measures. These findings suggest that actual–ideal discrepancies activate a promotion-focused orientation (Higgins 1998), motivating symbolic consumption to signal progress toward the ideal financial self. The results also extend compensatory consumption theory (Mandel et al. 2021), demonstrating that actual–ideal discrepancies prompt symbolic self-completion, consistent with effects observed in other domains like ability (Liu et al. 2025a), religion (Syahrivar et al. 2022), and status (Kim and Jang 2020).

Studies 2A, 2B, and 2C demonstrated that when consumers experienced discrepancies between their current finances and financial obligations, their luxury preference decreased. This pattern aligns with prevention-focused regulation (Higgins 1998), in which luxury products are viewed as financially irresponsible (Dubois et al. 2021). These results support prior research showing that prevention-focused consumers avoid risk and indulgence (Pandey and Tripathi 2022; Park and Ryu 2025). They also reinforce compensatory consumption research by showing that self-discrepancies can suppress symbolic self-completion strategies when it conflicts with internalized obligations (Mandel et al. 2021).

Study 3 found that although financial actual–ideal discrepancy reduced hedonic well-being, it did not mediate luxury preference. This suggests that short-term emotional discomfort may be insufficient to drive luxury preference. Alternatively, actual–ideal discrepancy may influence luxury preference through mechanisms beyond immediate affect. In contrast, financial actual–ought discrepancy lowered eudaimonic well-being, which was associated with reduced luxury preference. However, this finding should be interpreted cautiously due to the cross-sectional nature of the data. The effect may reflect social desirability bias, with participants downplaying their interest in luxury to conform to norms of financial prudence. It may also reflect cultural values in Australia that emphasize modesty and egalitarianism (Saunders and Wong 2013).

Study 4 revealed that under high financial actual–ideal discrepancy, consumers preferred renting and second-hand luxury formats, which provide symbolic and hedonic benefits with lower financial commitment. Conversely, co-ownership was the least preferred format, likely because its novelty and diluted ownership limit its symbolic value. These findings extend the regulatory focus account established in Studies 1A–1C and 3.

While financial actual–ideal discrepancies trigger a promotion focus that motivates luxury preference, Study 4 shows that this promotion focus does not generalize to all access-based luxury formats. Instead, consumers strategically choose formats that

still allow them to signal progress toward the ideal financial self through exclusivity and psychological ownership. In this sense, renting and second-hand formats may operate as a form of cognitive reappraisal or identity-safe consumption, allowing consumers to reinterpret financial actual–ideal discrepancies while still pursuing symbolic progress toward the ideal financial self. This pattern underscores the central role of promotion-focused regulation, in which consumers seek advancement toward their financial aspirations, but only through formats that preserve identity expression. By contrast, formats that dilute ownership, such as co-ownership, are inconsistent with symbolic self-completion strategies and therefore less attractive.

5 | Conclusion

5.1 | Theoretical Contribution

This study offers several key theoretical contributions to the literature on consumer psychology, luxury marketing, and positive psychology. First, it extends self-discrepancy theory into the financial domain, which is an area that remains underexplored despite its growing relevance (Rauber et al. 2024). While past research examines self-discrepancies in domains such as power, social identity, and competence (Kim and Jang 2020; Rauber et al. 2024; Rucker and Galinsky 2008), few studies investigate how consumers evaluate their financial position beyond objective income or external deprivation. This study shows how financial actual–ideal and actual–ought discrepancies activate distinct motivational orientations, shaping opposite luxury preference outcomes. This distinction helps reconcile inconsistent findings in the luxury literature on whether financial strain increases or suppresses luxury preference.

Second, it brings renewed attention to the overlooked concept of actual–ought discrepancy (Hu et al. 2022). Although central to self-discrepancy theory (Higgins 1987), the ought self receives limited attention in consumer research. This study demonstrates that not all self-discrepancies prompt compensatory behavior. Activation of the ought self-guide elicits regulatory restraint, leading consumers to avoid luxury products that conflict with perceived obligations. Moreover, since individuals may experience both actual–ideal and actual–ought discrepancies concurrently, the pursuit of self-enhancement may be curtailed when obligations become more salient. These findings complement compensatory consumption theory by showing that self-discrepancies can lead to avoidance-based strategies, such as dissociation or escapism (Mandel et al. 2021).

Third, this study contributes to positive psychology by demonstrating how self-discrepancies affect consumer well-being. Financial actual–ought discrepancy reduces eudaimonic well-being, which in turn reduces luxury preference. This highlights that financial self-discrepancies are not merely economic judgments but also key drivers of psychological functioning. This study also extends prior research that focuses mainly on hedonic affect or guilt (Pupelis and Šeinauskienė 2023; Syahrivar et al. 2022). Additionally, not all discrepancies operate through short-term emotional discomfort. These findings

challenge assumptions in the compensatory consumption literature that hedonic well-being is the primary driver of luxury and materialistic behaviors (Pupelis and Šeinauskienė 2023).

Finally, this study advances the luxury marketing literature by identifying access-based luxury formats as a psychological boundary condition. Even promotion-focused consumers do not uniformly prefer all forms of affordable luxury. Financially ideal-discrepant consumers prefer formats that allow symbolic self-completion without undermining feelings of ownership or exclusivity, while co-ownership fails to fulfill these needs. This finding extends prior research by Dias et al. (2022), which shows that financially constrained consumers are more sensitive to opportunity costs, suggesting that even these consumers weigh financial trade-offs when choosing how to engage with luxury.

5.2 | Managerial Implications

This study offers several actionable insights for luxury marketers seeking to navigate the psychological complexities of financially constrained consumers. First, brands should avoid promoting luxury during periods when social or financial obligations are salient. Financial actual–ought discrepancies suppress luxury preference due to prevention-focused mechanisms. Hence, marketers should be cautious when launching luxury campaigns during occasions such as tax season, back-to-school months, or major cultural holidays involving familial obligations (e.g., Lunar New Year). Promoting luxury at these times may backfire, as actual–ought discrepancies are likely to be top-of-mind, amplifying perceptions of inauthenticity and exacerbating eudaimonic distress. Instead, brands can strategically time campaigns to coincide with aspirational occasions such as graduation season or career promotions, when consumers are more focused on self-improvements and personal milestones. Events like Singles' Day or International Women's Day also offer opportunities to position luxury as a means of self-recognition and empowerment.

Given that self-discrepancy can be situationally primed (Rauber et al. 2024), marketers should frame luxury not as indulgence but as an earned recognition of effort and transformation, effectively activating financial actual–ideal discrepancies. Messaging should emphasize themes of self-elevation, future potential, and identity alignment rather than focusing solely on prestige or exclusivity. For example, a campaign targeting early-career professionals could use promotion-oriented messaging such as “From where you were to who you have become” or “You have earned more than a title”, positioning luxury as a symbolic marker of personal growth.

Access-based luxury formats also offer strategic opportunities. Rather than being framed as budget compromises, rental and second-hand services should be positioned as aspirational lifestyle choices that align with consumers' ideal financial self. These models act as psychological enablers, allowing consumers with financial identity gaps to engage with luxury without undermining progress or status. By offering symbolic access at lower financial cost, rental or subscription models let brands

reach financially constrained consumers while preserving brand equity. Rental services can be positioned as low-risk, low-commitment pathways to temporary self-enhancement, while second-hand luxury products can be framed as heritage-rich, value-savvy acquisitions that signal both smart consumption and symbolic progress. By contrast, co-ownership formats should be promoted with caution, as shared ownership may dilute exclusivity and undermine consumers' symbolic self-completion needs.

Beyond managerial considerations, these findings also highlight societal implications. Access-based formats reduce psychological exclusion by offering consumers symbolic entry points into luxury, even when constrained by finances. This contributes to inclusive consumption and resonates with ongoing debates about economic inequality and ethical branding. By positioning renting and second-hand luxury as aspirational rather than inferior, brands can expand participation in luxury products while showing sensitivity to diverse financial realities.

At the same time, luxury strategies capitalizing on consumer aspirations raise ethical concerns about exploitation and inequality. Consumers with financial self-discrepancies may overextend themselves to purchase luxury they cannot sustainably afford, which may create financial strain. This underscores a tension between symbolic self-completion and consumer vulnerability. From a stakeholder perspective, consumers face psychological and financial costs, while brands risk reputational harm if campaigns are seen as exploitative. To mitigate this, marketers should pair aspirational promotions with responsible alternatives, such as renting and second-hand formats, which allow symbolic engagement without unsustainable financial burden.

5.3 | Limitations and Future Research Directions

This study has several limitations that suggest directions for future investigation. First, its conceptual scope is limited. It examined financial actual-ideal and actual-ought discrepancies in isolation, although aspirations and obligations often co-occur. Their interaction may produce complex effects, such as actual-ought discrepancies moderating the influence of actual-ideal discrepancies on luxury preference. In addition, while most studies demonstrated medium to large effects, some (e.g., Studies 1C and 2B; see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix A) yielded smaller effects, suggesting that the magnitude of self-discrepancy effects may vary with context or individual factors. Future research should examine these joint influences and boundary conditions, including moderators such as cultural norms, financial literacy, or social desirability bias, to better capture the dynamic nature of financial self-discrepancies.

Second, this study has a methodological limitation. Some studies relied on cross-sectional designs (Studies 1B, 2B; see Supporting Information S1: Web Appendix A), which limit causal inference, while others used artificial scenarios (e.g., Study 2C) which may not fully capture the complexity of real-world financial decisions. Moreover, the reliance on hypothetical preferences may not fully reflect actual consumer behavior.

Future research could adopt longitudinal or ethnographic approaches and incorporate behavioral indicators such as purchase data, browsing time, or platform engagement to assess the cumulative and practical consequences of financial self-discrepancies over time.

Third, this study has a limitation on contextual sensitivity. Because self-discrepancy is culturally and contextually shaped (Rauber et al. 2024), the meanings of financial aspirations and obligations may vary across income levels or cultural settings, and most individuals are likely to experience some degree of self-discrepancy. The concern lies more in the type, salience, and intensity of the discrepancy than in its mere presence. Future research should extend this model across diverse cultural and income contexts, and investigate thresholds at which discrepancies become psychologically consequential.

Beyond these limitations, several avenues suggest future directions. Although this study identified eudaimonic well-being as a mediator of financial actual-ought discrepancies, no equivalent mediator was observed for actual-ideal discrepancies. Future studies could test alternative mechanisms such as self-enhancement needs (Wang et al. 2023) and product perception (Rucker and Galinsky 2008). Further research should also consider the potential psychological risks of luxury preference among financially vulnerable consumers, examining how marketers and policymakers can design more responsible forms of messaging.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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Supporting Information

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section.
Supplementary document v2.